

सेण्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया Central Bank of India	DEMAND NOTICE 13(2) OF SECURITISATION ACT 2002	
1911 से आपक लिए "केन्द्रित" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911		
BRANCH OFFICE: DDA MANGLAPURI, NEW DELHI-110045		
<u>Demand Notice Under Section 13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and</u>		
<u>Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act, 2002 to the Borrower/s and Guarantor/s.</u>		
This Demand Notice is hereby given under section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002) read with rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 hereinafter calling upon the under mentioned Borrowers / Guarantors to repay, the amounts outstanding for the Credit Facilities granted to them / on their Guarantee, within 60 days from the date of this Notice. If you fail to repay to the Bank the below mentioned amount with further interest and incidental expenses, costs etc. in terms of this notice u/s 13(2) of the Act, the Bank will exercise all or any of the rights detailed under Sub-Section (4) of Section 13 and under other applicable provisions of the said Act. You are also put on notice that in terms of sub-section 4 of Section 13 you shall not transfer by sale, lease or otherwise the said secured assets detailed below of this notice without obtaining written consent of the Bank. The details of the account and secured Assets along with Amount Outstanding is given below:-		
SCHEDULE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY & OTHER DETAILS		
Name & Address of Borrower and Guarantor	Description of the Secured Asset	Date & Amount of 13(2) Notice
<u>BORROWER:</u>	<u>(Detailed description of the secured Asset/ Mortgaged Property/ Hypothecated Goods)</u>	Date of 13(2) Notice: 26/03/2026
<u>MR. SUMANJAY KUMAR</u>	<u>IMMOVABLE ASSET:</u>	NPA : 20/03/2026
<u>/O MADAN MOHAN</u>	Property Bearing No. H-2/21A, built on Plot No.H-21-A, Land measuring 100 Sq.yds. i.e. 83.61 Sq.Meters, 2nd Floor without Roof Terrace Rights out of Khalsa No.84/10 & 84/11, situated in the area of Village Palam, Delhi State colony known as Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi-110045.	Rs.4,29,669.80
<u>Address 1: E-97/24 Flat No.303 Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi-110045.</u>	<u>Bounded By:</u>	(Rupees Four Lakh Twenty Nine Thousand Six Hundred Sixty Nine and Eighty Paise Only) with further interest at the applicable rate/s of interest mentioned in the Schedule A from the date of notice 26/03/2026 till the date of full and final payment along with incidental expenses, charges and costs recoverable from you as per terms of contract and/or as per law, within sixty days from the date of this notice.
<u>Address 2: H-2/21A Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi</u>	<u>East: Plot No.H-20</u>	
<u>GUARANTOR:</u>	<u>West: Other's Property</u>	
<u>MR. SACHIN KUMAR</u>	<u>North: Other's Property</u>	
<u>/O MR. RAM BHARDA PATHAK</u>	<u>South : Gali 10' Wide</u>	
<u>Address: RZ H 2/27 Bangali Colony, Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi-110045.</u>		
YOUR ATTENTION IS DRAWN TO THE PROVISIONS OF SECTION 13(8) OF THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002 IN RESPECT OF TIME AVAILABLE TO YOU TO REDEEM THE SECURED ASSETS.		
DATE: 30.04.2026		
PLACE: NEW DELHI		

Three children drown in Dwarka golf course pond

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a tragic incident, three children drowned in a pond at a golf course in a 15-foot-deep pond after scaling the boundary wall of a golf course in Dwarka's Sector 24 area on Thursday morning.

According to police, the deceased have been identified as two brothers, Ravi Jaiswal (8) and Veer Jaiswal (11), residents of Goyla Dairy, and Harsh (11), the son of a vagrant.

A PCR call was received at 7:07 am, and a police team rushed to the spot. Other emergency services, including the fire brigade, were also alerted, a senior police officer said. He said the three children scaled the golf course wall, which has only one entrance gate manned by a guard, and then went swimming.

"While a security guard noticed some clothes lying on the ground around 7:30 pm on Wednesday, he failed to



PANKAJ KUMAR

locate the children. He didn't alert anyone else either," the officer said. He said in the early hours of Thursday, bodies started floating in the water, which staff noticed, and the police were alerted.

"Upon reaching the location, police found three children dead in a pond inside the golf course premises. Fire department personnel assisted in retrieving the bodies," Deputy Commissioner of Police (Dwarka) Kushalpal Singh said.

The bodies have been sent for postmortem. Forensic teams have also been called to gather evidence from the spot, they said. Police said an

investigation is underway to ascertain the circumstances leading to the drowning.

Preliminary investigation revealed that the children's clothes were found lying outside the pond, suggesting that they had likely entered the water to bathe. It is suspected that they accidentally drowned.

A local resident said, "I was passing through this area to my house in Goyla Dairy when I noticed a crowd here. I saw the police taking the bodies of three children. Earlier, years ago, four children also died here. I don't know exactly if they died by drowning or were murdered."

No coercion, no captive buying: CM Rekha warns private schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has directed that every private school must make a clear written disclosure on its notice board, website, and at any in-house store that parents are free to purchase uniforms, books and stationery from any vendor of their choice. The Government made it clear that any violation or irregularity will invite strict action against the school, including a possible government takeover.

As per her directions, every private school must make a clear written disclosure on its notice board, website, and at any in-house store that parents are free to purchase uniforms, books and stationery from any vendor of their choice. She made it clear that any violation or irregularity will invite strict action against the school, including a possible government takeover.

In a stern warning to Delhi private schools, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday vowed the toughest legal action, including takeover,



against institutions coercing parents to buy books, uniforms and stationery from a single or designated vendor.

She said every school must state on its notice board, website and at any store it operates that parents are free to purchase uniforms, books and stationery from anywhere. The chief minister has warned that she may carry out surprise inspections at any school.

In a video message, Rekha Gupta said, "I can walk into any private school in Delhi for an inspection, anytime. Every school will state it clearly on its notice board, on its website, and at any store it

operates that parents are free to buy uniforms, books and stationery from anywhere. There will be no coercion, no captive buying, and no single-vendor diktat."

"Ensure this without exception," she said, adding that any violation, any manipulation, will invite the toughest action available under the law. A takeover is not beyond consideration. My inspections are not a gimmick. They are enforcement in action. They are driven by the voices of parents who have written to me, telling me where I must go next," she added. "Fixing Delhi is

our responsibility. My Delhi, My responsibility," she added.

In a press statement, the chief minister's office said the Government stressed that no parent can be compelled to purchase items from the school or from any single designated vendor. Schools may, for convenience, suggest a list of five to six vendors, but no purchase can be made mandatory. She directed officials to ensure full compliance, underlining that this is not a routine instruction but a matter of serious concern.

Any deviation, she said, will lead to the strictest possible action, including takeover if necessary.

It also clarified that her inspections are not symbolic but based on complaints and suggestions received

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Govt to launch Yamuna cruise service next month

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is all set to start a cruise service on the Yamuna next month as part of its river rejuvenation and tourism development programme, according to a source. The government will announce the launch date within 15 days. The source said that the 40-seater vessel, built in Mumbai and transported to Delhi in January, has since undergone extensive interior work.

He said the cruise is now fully furnished, decorated, equipped, and ready for operations. The service is expected to be inaugurated by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and will include onboard facilities such as music, entertainment and food services for passengers, he said. He said the cruise will operate on the Yamuna, offering hour-long round trips designed to provide a unique recreational experience within the city.

The project forms part of a broader riverfront development plan aimed at transforming the Yamuna into a hub for recreation and leisure. The source said the government is also planning to introduce water sports and other recreational activities at the cruise terminal, creating a more comprehensive leisure zone

along the river.

The initiative, he said, is intended to provide Delhiites with experiences comparable to those available in popular tourist destinations such as Goa without requiring them to travel outside the city, he said. The objective is to deliver an international-standard experience at affordable prices, making it accessible to a wider section of the public, he said.

The cruise is part of the Delhi government's riverfront tourism and recreation plan and will operate on a six-to-seven-kilometre stretch between Sonia Vihar and Jagatpur, upstream of the Wazirabad barrage.

The project, which is being developed at an estimated cost of ₹20 crore, is expected to provide a green tourism experience to people. The government had said earlier, "The Chief Minister will dedicate it to the people of Delhi. We are bringing this in accordance with international safety standards."

The Yamuna has two phases in Delhi: upstream Wazirabad and downstream Wazirabad. For upstream Wazirabad, we are working to connect people with the Yamuna. Downstream Wazirabad, the sewage is being tapped first. Systems are being built to treat it.

DDA directed to integrate spiritual tourism in Yamuna ghats redevelopment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu has directed the DDA to integrate elements of "spiritual tourism" while redeveloping ghats along the Yamuna, officials said on Thursday.

Recently, Sandhu held a meeting with Delhi Development Authority officials on the rejuvenation and restoration of the Yamuna Bazar and its ghats near the Kashmere Gate area.

"I have instructed officials to further refine the restoration plan by integrating elements of spiritual tourism, expanding green spaces and creating sustainable livelihood opportunities for residents," Sandhu said.

Earlier this month, Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visited the Yamuna Bazar area and said that the floodplain from Palla to Kalindi Kunj will be developed as eco-friendly spaces in line with the Vasudev Ghat area. In May last year, Gupta performed the Yamuna Aarti at Vasudev Ghat to mark 100 days of her government in the city.

The entire stretch of the river in the national capital is approximately 55 kilome-



tres. During the earlier visit, the LG directed DDA to prepare a comprehensive plan to revitalise this important heritage stretch.

"While Vasudev Ghat, along with other restored ghats such as Asita, Baansera, and Yamuna Biodiversity Park, has emerged as an eco-friendly, sustainable, and green public space on the floodplains. Several other ghats still need to be developed on similar lines by DDA with the cooperation of other departments," Sandhu said.

Sandhu also directed officials to ensure robust flood mitigation measures to ensure the long-term resilience of the area.

The low-lying area of Yamuna Bazar along the Ring Road is prone to water-logging during the monsoon season, and floodwater also enters the main road, hampering traffic movement.

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Delhi (Municipal Corporation of Delhi)

Self-Enumeration
1st - 15th May

Houselisting
16th May - 14th June

***Self-Enumeration period is over for New Delhi Municipal Council and Delhi Cantonment Board areas.**
Houselisting process is currently underway and will continue till 15th May.

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ICSE and ISC results declared, girls outperform boys in both



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Council for the Indian School Certificate Examinations on Thursday declared the Class 10 and Class 12 results for 2026, with overall pass percentages of 99.18 per cent and 99.13 per cent, respectively. A total of 2,58,721 candidates appeared for the Indian Certificate of Secondary Education (ICSE), or Class 10, examination. About 1,03,316 students took

the Indian School Certificate (ISC), or Class 12, exam. Girls outperformed boys in both examinations. In ICSE, girls recorded a pass percentage of 99.46 per cent compared to 98.93 per cent for boys. In ISC, girls achieved a 99.48 per cent pass percentage, while those of boys stood at 98.81 per cent. In the ICSE exam, 2,56,590 candidates qualified, while 2,131 did not clear the exam. In the ISC exam, 1,02,414 candidates qualified, while 902 did not.

Haj pilgrims to pay ₹10K more due to high ATF prices

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Haj Committee of India has raised the Haj airfare by ₹10,000 per pilgrim this year due to a sharp global rise in Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) prices, with the Centre asserting that the increase has been restricted through hard negotiations. The Haj airfare hike has drawn criticism from Opposition leaders, who have stated that such an increase amounts to "injustice". A circular issued by the Haj Committee of India said in view of the extraordinary circumstances arising out of the ongoing crisis in the Middle

East, a one-time revision in the airfare for Haj 2026 has been approved by the Ministry of Minority Affairs. "The revised airfare entails an additional amount of \$100 per pilgrim, irrespective of embarkation point, to be borne by the pilgrims. The decision has been taken in view of pressing requests from airlines for revision of base fare by more than \$400 on account of the sharp increase in Aviation Turbine Fuel prices due to the prevailing situation in the Middle East, after due examination of facts and consultation with stakeholders," the circular said. Accordingly, all Haj pilgrims this year are required to

Mizoram declared insurgency-free as last militant group lays down arms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Aizawl

The last remaining ethnic insurgent group of Mizoram laid down arms on Thursday, and the state became "insurgency-free", Chief Minister Lalduhoma said. Although it remained dormant for several years, a faction of the Hmar People's Convention (Democratic) or HPC(D), headed by Lalhmingthanga Sanate, indulged in sporadic criminal activities at irregular intervals, officials said.

The Sanate faction was considered the last surviving insurgent group in the northeastern State. The HPC(D) had been demanding an autonomous district council for the Hmar community people under



the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution. A total of 43 cadres of the group, including Sanate, surrendered their weapons to the government during a "homecoming and arms laying ceremony" at Sesawng near Aizawl during the day. The 'homecoming ceremony' follows the peace

accord signed between the Mizoram Government and the HPC(D) on April 14, effectively marking the end of insurgency in the State. Speaking at the event, Lalduhoma said that the shadow of HPC(D) insurgency remained in mind whenever peace was spoken of in Mizoram in the past.

"We approached negotiations with an open heart to reach an agreement. Our home minister and his colleagues worked tirelessly. Today, we have reached our goal. Now, with a peaceful heart, we can proudly say Mizoram is a truly peaceful state," the Chief Minister said. Urging various Mizo tribes to reunite, Lalduhoma emphasised that no single tribe stands above the identity of being Mizo. "We are all Mizos. If subtribes within the Mizo community try to stand entirely on their own today, it is unlikely they would succeed. We must find contentment in our shared Mizo identity. We will thrive only through unity," he said.



deposit ₹10,000 towards the differential airfare by May 15, it added. In a post on X, Minority Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said for countless families, Haj is a once-in-a-lifetime dream nurtured over years.

"I deeply respect that sentiment. Amid a sharp global rise in Aviation Turbine Fuel prices, driven by ongoing geopolitical tensions, airlines sought a steep hike of \$300-\$400 per pilgrim. We also

can't blame airlines for the rise in Aviation Turbine Fuel price," he said. Through negotiations, it was ensured that the increase was restricted to just \$100, saving each pilgrim a significant amount, Rijiju said. The decision was taken transparently and in good faith to ensure no disruption in the Haj 2026 operations, he added. The minority affairs ministry said various concerns and comments have been raised on several media platforms regarding the ₹10,000 increase in the Haj airfare. "We share the concerns for every pilgrim who saves for years to perform Haj. That

is precisely why the Haj Committee negotiated hard on their behalf," it said. The ministry said the facts are that the airlines demanded \$300 to \$400 extra per pilgrim due to the sharp rise in ATF prices caused by the Middle-East crisis — a global emergency beyond any Government's control. "After extensive negotiation and due consultation with stakeholders, the Ministry of Minority Affairs approved a one-time revision of only \$100 per pilgrim, irrespective of embarkation point — a saving of \$300 per pilgrim compared to what airlines originally sought," it said.

River cruise boat overturns in Jabalpur district; 4 drown

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jabalpur



Four people drowned when a cruise boat carrying 35 to 40 passengers overturned in the Bargi river in Jabalpur district after encountering a sudden storm on Thursday, a police official said. Eighteen people were rescued, while 15 to 18 are still missing, said City Superintendent of Police (Bargi town) Anjul Mishra. Mishra said 35 to 40 people

were on the river cruise boat when it overturned because of a sudden storm. Four bodies were recovered from the river.

Bangladesh summons acting Indian envoy over Assam CM's remarks

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs in Bangladesh on Thursday summoned acting Indian High Commissioner to Dhaka, Pawan Badhe, and conveyed its concerns over recent remarks made by Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma. According to officials, Director General (South Asia) Ishrat Jahan met Badhe in the afternoon and formally communicated Dhaka's position. An official familiar with the development said Bangladesh viewed the comments as "dis-

paraging" to bilateral relations and expressed its displeasure to the Indian side. The move comes in response to a statement made by Sarma on April 26, in which he claimed that 20 foreign nationals had been apprehended in Assam and "pushed back" into Bangladesh. In a post on X, Sarma wrote: "Rude people don't understand soft language. We continuously remind ourselves of this prophetic line when we expel infiltrators from Assam who don't leave themselves. For instance, these 20 illegal Bangladeshis who were PUSHED



BACK last night," according to Indian media reports. Bangladesh raised concerns over the tone and content of the remarks, stressing that public statements capable of straining ties between the two neighbouring countries are counterproductive. It also underscored the importance of exercising restraint while addressing sensitive bilateral matters. The development highlights ongoing sensitivities surrounding migration and border-related issues between India and Bangladesh, which have periodically surfaced in public discourse.

Exit polls: Mamata alleges media hype

Simultaneously, the ruling LDF in on Thursday said that the exit polls did not show an anti-incumbency feeling among the people, while the opposition UDF welcomed the predictions, saying they were similar to the outcome expected by the Congress-led front. Several exit polls on Wednesday predicted a thumping victory for the BJP in Assam and a clear edge for the party over the ruling TMC in West Bengal, while projecting a return of the DMK Government in Tamil Nadu and a comeback by the Congress-led UDF in Kerala after 10 years. However, some pollsters predicted a big win for the TMC in West Bengal and a hung House in Tamil Nadu, with actor-turned-politician Vijay's TVK emerging as a spoiler for the DMK. Almost all forecasts indicated a return to power for the AINRC-led NDA Government in Puducherry.

Iran draws line on nuclear, missile...

The US blockade is designed to prevent Iran from selling its oil, depriving it of crucial revenue while also potentially creating a situation where Tehran has to shut off production because it has nowhere to store oil. The Strait's closure is also problem for the US' Gulf allies, which use the waterway to export their oil and gas. A recent Iranian proposal would push negotiations on the country's nuclear program to a later date. Trump said one of the major reasons he went to war was to deny Iran the ability to develop nuclear weapons. Iran long has maintained its program is peaceful, though it enriched uranium at near-weapons-grade levels of 60%. Pakistan on Thursday said it was still facilitating indirect talks between the US and Iran aimed at easing tensions, but Islamabad would also welcome direct communication between the two sides, even by phone. "If the two parties can engage in real-time conversations, that could ease the sticking points," said Ministry of Foreign Affairs spokesperson Tahir Andrabi at a weekly news briefing. He declined to share details of any Iranian or US proposals. Speaking to mark Persian Gulf Day in Iran, Khamenei's remarks signaled that nuclear issues and Iran's ballistic missile program wouldn't be traded away. "Ninety million proud and honorable Iranians inside and outside the country regard all of

Iran's identity-based, spiritual, human, scientific, industrial and technological capacities — from nanotechnology and biotechnology to nuclear and missile capabilities — as national assets, and will protect them just as they protect the country's waters, land and airspace," Khamenei said. Khamenei referred to America as the "Great Satan," a long hurled insult by Iranian leaders toward the US since the 1979 Islamic Revolution. He said Americans should have no business in the Persian Gulf. "Foreigners who come from thousands of kilometres away to act with greed and malice there have no place in it — except at the bottom of its waters," said Khamenei, who was reportedly wounded in the Feb 28 attack that killed his father, the 86-year-old Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. In his remarks, Khamenei seemed to signal Iran would maintain its control over the waterway, which sits in the territorial waters of Iran and Oman. Iran had been charging some ships reportedly \$2 million apiece to travel through the strait. He said that Iran's control of the Strait of Hormuz will make the Gulf more secure, and that Tehran's "legal rules and new management" of the strait will benefit all the region's nations. However, the world considered the strait an international waterway, open to all without paying tolls. Gulf Arab nations, chief among them the United Arab Emirates, have denied Iran's control of the strait as akin to piracy. **JeM ultra killed in Pakistan** Some social media accounts in Pakistan, noted that Maulana Azahar was the second JeM-linked figure from the same location to die in similar circumstances in recent weeks. No official statement has been issued by Pakistani authorities or the JeM leadership confirming the death or providing further details. The incident has drawn significant attention in India's security circles, with many observers pointing to the pattern of unexplained eliminations of high-profile JeM operatives on Pakistani soil. Social media users have widely shared the news with references to 'Dhurandhar' a popular meme alluding to covert, untraceable actions against terror figures living in Pakistan. JeM, designated as a terrorist organisation by India, the United States and the United Nations, has long maintained its primary base in Bahawalpur. The group has been linked to several major attacks on Indian soil, including

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the 2001 Parliament attack, Pathankot airbase attack and 2019 Pulwama suicide bombing.

ISI spy ring busted in Punjab

"Preliminary investigation reveals that the accused, along with his associates, had been installing these solar-powered CCTV cameras at various locations to monitor sensitive sites, including establishments linked to the Army, and transmitting live footage to Pakistan-based handlers through mobile applications. Further investigation is underway to trace forward and backward linkages and identify other members of the module. Punjab Police reiterates its commitment to neutralizing these networks for public safety", the DGP added. Investigations show the accused and associates installed these cameras at strategic locations to monitor Army-linked establishments and sensitive sites. Live feeds were allegedly sent to Pakistan-based handlers through mobile applications. The cameras tracked Army troop movements and sent live feeds to Pakistan handlers. Two-phase operation: initial arrests in Punjab/Delhi, followed by more in Punjab based on Military Intelligence inputs. NIA has taken over aspects of the probe, examining wider networks, foreign funding and funding trails. Investigators say that operatives were reportedly paid ₹8,000 to ₹10,000 for each camera. Investigations by Punjab Police and earlier Delhi Police operations have found the use of low-cost, off-the-shelf tech like solar CCTVs with 4G to monitor troop movements and critical infrastructure. Punjab being a border state, has seen repeated attempts at such hybrid threats involving espionage, arms smuggling and reconnaissance. Punjab has seen a notable uptick in ISI-backed espionage cases in 2025-2026, driven by hybrid warfare tactics from Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI). These often involve local recruits including youth and ex-military personnel, using low-cost technology like China-made solar-powered 4G CCTV cameras to conduct real-time surveillance of sensitive military and Army-linked sites. Footage is transmitted live via mobile apps to handlers in Pakistan. Punjab Police's CIU, State Special Operation Cell (SSOC) and coordinated operations with Delhi Police Special Cell and Military Intelligence have led to multiple busts. "The networks rely on low-cost China-made solar-powered 4G CCTV cameras to monitor Army cantonments, troop movements and sensitive installations, streaming live footage to han-

dlers in Pakistan via mobile apps. Operatives use social media recruitment, cheap solar CCTVs and encrypted apps for discreet surveillance, often paid small sums per installation", said a senior intelligence official. Punjab Police, under DGP Gaurav Yadav has adopted intelligence-led operations with inter-agency support to dismantle these networks swiftly. Punjab Police has intensified its fight against hybrid threats from Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) with multiple espionage modules uncovered in 2025-2026. This follows a major April 10, 2026 operation by Delhi Police Special Cell in coordination with Punjab Police and Military Intelligence. Eleven people including eight from Punjab were arrested across multiple states. Nine solar-powered cameras were seized near defence sites in Kapurthala, Jalandhar, Pathankot, Patiala and Moga. The ISI-Babbar Khalsa International-linked module also involved arms smuggling. The National Investigation Agency (NIA) is now probing wider linkages and funding to various modules. **Nepal Airline apologises over incorrect India map** Reaffirming its regional ties, Nepal Airlines emphasised its commitment to maintaining positive relationships. "We deeply value our strong relationships with our neighbours and partners and sincerely regret any offence or misunderstanding this incident may have caused," the statement said. The incident highlights the potential diplomatic and public relations fallout that can arise from even inadvertent errors in official communications-especially when they involve disputed or sensitive geopolitical regions. The map, which circulated widely before being taken down, showed the Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh within Pakistan's borders. The depiction drew sharp criticism from Indian social media users, many of whom called for accountability and clarification. Among those reacting was Bhojpuri actor and Former MP Khesari Lal Yadav, who described the map as a "deliberate act" and urged the airline to explain the discrepancy. Several users also expressed concern that such incidents could strain India-Nepal relations, noting India's longstanding economic and developmental support to Nepal, including in areas such as fuel supply, infrastructure projects, and disaster relief. Others alleged that the controversy reflects a broader pattern of messaging by Nepal's current

establishment that is occasionally critical of India-though no official linkage has been established. Nepal Airlines has since reiterated that the error was unintentional and assured that safeguards are being put in place to prevent similar incidents in the future. **Minor can't be forced to give birth: SC** Minor mother will have lifelong health issues and cannot reproduce... This child can be given for adoption. It has been 30 weeks now. It is a viable life now," Bhati said. The bench asked AIIMS to counsel the survivor's parents and said the decision has to be of the person concerned. "There are children for adoption. In this country we have lot of sympathies...There are deserted, abandoned children on the streets and even mafias on it. We have to look at them. This is an unwanted pregnancy of a 15-year-old child," it said. During the proceedings, an AIIMS doctor told the court that it is not child versus foetus but child versus child. Bhati also sought the court's permission for counselling with the teen and her parents. At this juncture, Justice Bagchi said, "Who has stopped you? What is your Parens patriae (parent of the nation) approach? Give respect to your citizen. Show data to the parents and if they choose to keep it. Then so be it. "But if they think the mental health is in jeopardy then they will take a call. Please do not press your curative. The curative can come from the parents. Let us not make a fight between state and its citizens. Bring in a psychiatrist and counsellor. Let us not choose for people capable for choosing." It is not for AIIMS, the judge said, to choose for citizens and it can only render medical service. The top court said the decision on termination has to be that of the survivor and her parents. AIIMS, it said, may help them take an informed decision. "Explain everything to the child and her parents. If after that they want to change views then we will see," the bench said. Observing that the reproductive autonomy of a mother-to-be must be accorded the highest importance, a bench of Justices B V Nagarathna and Ujjal Bhuyan last week allowed the 15-year-old to medically terminate her pregnancy of 30 weeks. The top court also dismissed the review plea filed by AIIMS and held that medical termination of unwanted pregnancy cannot be rejected on grounds of advanced stage of pregnancy or normalcy of foetus. Not allowing the termination on that basis would "render the right to bodily autonomy nugatory", the bench said.

Nation Focus

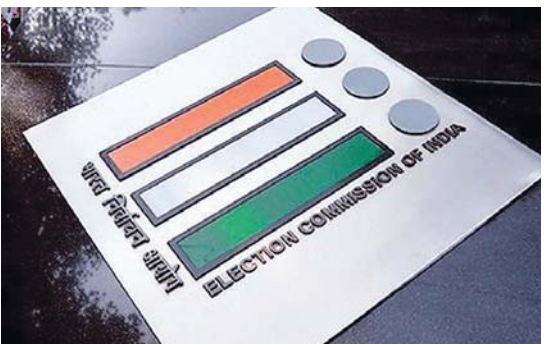
Singh, while seeing off the Haj pilgrims at the Imphal airport, said, "I pray to the Almighty that they reach the destination safe and sound. I urge the pilgrims to offer prayers to establish a peaceful Manipur." A total of 172 pilgrims left for Kolkata on Wednesday, while 207 devotees departed on Thursday.

States Focus



CONFIDENT WE ARE GOING TO WIN KERALA: SHASHI THAROOR

Congress leader Shashi Tharoor on Thursday expressed confidence in the victory of the United Democratic Front (UDF) in Kerala, saying the Congress-led alliance will win more than 75 seats out of the total 140 in the State. Tharoor, who hails from Kerala, said he was not surprised to see the results of the exit polls, most of which predicted a victory for the UDF that has been out of power for 10 years in the State. "We have been on the ground. I have campaigned in 59 constituencies across 12 districts out of 14. I was very confident we are going to win."



ECI ASSESSING REPOLL PLEA IN 77 BOOTHS IN BENGL

The Election Commission of India is actively looking into demands for repolling in 77 booths across four Assembly constituencies in South 24 Parganas district after the second phase of West Bengal elections held on April 29, an official said on Thursday. The poll panel received 32 complaints of repolling from Falta, followed by Diamond Harbour (29), Magrahat (13) and three from Budge Budge, he said. Demands for repolling are generally made by political parties, candidates, polling agents, or even observers, citing specific irregularities such as EVM malfunction, booth capturing, intimidation, or violation of the secrecy of voting.

Will win clear majority in TN, Kerala: Kcharge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kalaburagi (Karnataka)

All India Congress Committee (AICC) President Mallikarjun Kcharge on Thursday expressed confidence that the alliances of which the Congress is a part, will get a clear majority in Tamil Nadu and Kerala, where Assembly elections were held earlier this month. In Assam, where Assembly polls were held on April 9, Congress will win more seats than the exit polls show, he said. He added that the grand old party gave a tough fight in Puducherry, and in West Bengal the fight has been for the party's growth. The counting of votes for all the five assemblies — West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Assam and Puducherry, will be taken up on May 4.



"Exit poll results are shown clearly for some places, but some results have created confusion. But I feel DMK will get a clear majority in Tamil Nadu, I have also spoken to people there. In the same way in Kerala, I have been told by our people that (Congress-led) UDF will get majority," Kcharge said in response to a question.

Speaking to reporters here, he said, "Exit polls have shown that in Assam we are not getting seats as expected, but I'm confident that we will get more seats than what they are showing. In Puducherry we have equally fought against BJP and N R Congress and we have expectations from there too. There was a tough

fight there; let's wait and see for a couple of days."

In West Bengal, according to exit polls and internal information there was a tough fight, Kcharge said, "As per our information TMC is ahead."

Alleging "oppression and intimidation" by the BJP and NDA through the deployment of central forces in West Bengal during polls, he said, "By doing that they have tried to give a strong fight to the Mamata Banerjee-led TMC."

"For Congress, our fight has been in West Bengal since the beginning. We have contested alone for the first time there. Our fight has been in the interest of the party and for the party's growth there," Kcharge added.

As per his feedback, the results will be as expected by the party. "Let's see, there are

three more days. If we say things now itself unnecessarily, it won't look good. If we wait for a couple of days, a clear picture will emerge, let's see what happens."

Several exit polls on Wednesday predicted a thumping victory for the BJP in Assam and a clear edge for the party over the ruling TMC in West Bengal, while projecting a return of the DMK Government in Tamil Nadu and a comeback by the Congress-led UDF in Kerala after 10 years.

However, some pollsters predicted a big win for the TMC in West Bengal and a hung House in Tamil Nadu with actor-turned politician Vijay's TVK emerging as a spoiler for the DMK.

Almost all forecast a return to power for the AINRC-led NDA Government in Puducherry.

ECI to roll out QR IDs for counting centres from May 4



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Election Commission of India (ECI) has decided to introduce QR code-based identity cards at counting centres to prevent unauthorised entry during vote counting for assembly elections in five States on May 4, an official said on Thursday.

The system will be implemented on counting day for the assembly polls in West Bengal, Assam, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Puducherry, as well as for bypolls in seven Assembly constituencies across five States. It will later be extended to all Lok Sabha and Assembly elections, the official said.

"To eliminate the possibility of any unauthorised persons from entering counting centres, the poll panel has introduced QR code-based photo identity cards. Under the system, a three-layer security arrangement has been put in place at the counting centres," he added. "At the first two security checkpoints, identity cards issued by the returning officer (RO) will be verified manually, while at the innermost security cordon near the counting hall, entry will be allowed only after successful QR code scanning," he said. "This is aimed at ensuring the highest standards of transparency, security and efficiency in the counting process," the official said.

5 injured in Behala TMC-BJP clash, 2 detained

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

At least five persons were injured in a clash between TMC and BJP supporters in south Kolkata's Behala on Wednesday night, hours after the second phase of West Bengal assembly polls ended, police said. The incident took place at Ramkrishnapalli in ward 129 under Behala Paschim, where the injured included former councillor and TMC leader Anjan Das, they said, adding that two persons were detained on Thursday in connection with the incident.

"A few of our party workers were sitting at a local office when a group of BJP-backed miscreants attacked them with bricks and bamboo sticks," a TMC leader in the locality alleged.

In the attack, Das sustained a head injury, while others suffered fractures and multiple injuries, he claimed.

The injured were taken to

Vidyasagar State General Hospital, and one of them was later shifted to SSKM Hospital as his condition worsened, a policeman said.

TMC candidate from Behala Paschim, Ratna Chatterjee, alleged that the attack was unprovoked.

"Polling was peaceful throughout the day, and our workers were told not to react to any provocation. But soon after it ended, they attacked our men with bricks and sticks. The manner in which Anjan Das was beaten is unacceptable," she said.

Sanghita Das, wife of the injured leader, claimed, "There was a rain of bricks. They came with rods and sticks and thrashed them mercilessly."

The BJP denied the allegations and blamed the TMC for initiating the violence. BJP leader Debjit Sarkar alleged that TMC supporters first attacked a saffron party worker.

"Anjan Das and his associates assaulted our worker, Prasenjit Brahma, a polling agent. They even went to his house and attacked



him. Locals intervened to rescue him," he said.

Police said the matter is being investigated, and police personnel have been deployed in the area to maintain law and order.

"We have received complaints

regarding the matter. We are gathering CCTV footage and cross-checking the claims. Strict action will be taken against those found guilty," he said.

The situation remained tense in the locality following the incident.

LDF denies anti-incumbency, UDF welcomes exit polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The ruling LDF in Kerala on Thursday said that the exit polls did not show an anti-incumbency feeling among the people, while the Opposition UDF welcomed the predictions, saying they were similar to the outcome expected by the Congress-led front.

A day after the exit polls predicted a UDF win in the Assembly elections held in the State on April 9, the BJP-led NDA claimed that there was a strong anti-incumbency feeling among the people, but no pro-UDF wave in the State.

Both the BJP-led National

Democratic Alliance (NDA) and the CPI(M)-headed Left Democratic Front (LDF), however, did not agree with the exit poll figures.

The LDF claimed it would return to power for a third time, while the NDA claimed it would gain more seats than what was predicted by the agencies which carried out the exit polls.

On the other hand, the Congress-led UDF welcomed the exit polls, saying that it was similar to the outcome predicted by it.

Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) chief Sunny Joseph and senior party leader K Muraliedharan said the exit poll figures were close to the numbers calculated by the



party and indicated that the UDF will come to power after the Assembly poll results are declared on May 4.

"So, as far as UDF is concerned, our win is assured," Muraliedharan told reporters and added that who will be the chief minister will be decided after May 4.

"We expect the people's verdict to be in favour of the UDF," Joseph said at a press conference.

Congress-ally and key UDF constituent, the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), also welcomed the exit polls, saying that it was similar to the outcome

predicted by the front.

IUML supremo Sadik Ali Shihab Thangal told media that since all the agencies which carried out the exit polls predicted a UDF win, it can be believed.

"We expect UDF to get more seats than what was predicted in the exit poll," he said.

Similar to the UDF, the LDF too expressed confidence of winning in the Assembly polls and termed the exit poll figures as inconsequential.

At the same time, the Left front claimed that the exit poll did not show any anti-incumbency factor

CPI(M) State secretary M V Govindan, LDF convener T P Ramakrishnan, State Tourism

Minister P A Mohamed Riyas and senior party leader N N Krishnadas were of the view that the exit polls were not important.

Govindan said the LDF was not worried as the exit polls actually show that the Left front will again come to power.

He also questioned the basis for the predictions that the BJP might win between 3-14 seats and asserted that the saffron party will not win even one.

Ramakrishnan, Riyas and Krishnadas also spoke along similar lines.

Krishnadas and Riyas said that exit polls predicted that LDF will lose in 2021, but were proved wrong.

Be at counting centres early: Vijay to TVK candidates

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

TVK candidate N Marie Wilson said that his party chief Vijay, during a meeting held here on Thursday, instructed candidates to be present at the counting centres early in the morning before the counting starts and "not move an inch".

Speaking to the media, RK Nagar candidate Wilson said, "Vijay asked us (TVK candidates) to be present at the counting centres by 6 am, advising us to stay at the front and closely monitor the proceedings, without moving an inch".

Elections to the 234-seat Tamil Nadu Assembly were held on April 23, and count-



ing of votes will take place on May 4.

The TVK candidates met Vijay to discuss their campaign experiences as well as preparations for May 4.

Wilson said they also shared their ground-level observations from their first-time electoral contest with the party leader.

Describing Vijay as a "very good listener", Wilson said the field issues faced during the election — including reported friction between TVK and DMK cadres in certain parts of Chennai — were reported, and the leadership took note of the events.

Addressing queries about recent exit polls that seemingly gave an edge to the DMK, Wilson clarified that exit polls were not discussed during their meeting with Vijay.

He said he would rather rely on "ground reality", stating that after travelling and interacting directly with the public for nearly 30 days, they are fully confident that the results will be in their favour as the voters have "already decided".

He also rubbished ongoing speculations regarding a potential alignment with the AIADMK.

"This has been going on for a while now, circulated by the media and some senior journalists over the past six months," added Wilson.

BJP to retain Assam; Bengal will see change: Dharmendra Pradhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Union Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Thursday said the BJP would retain power in Assam, while expressing confidence that there would be a change of Government in West Bengal, citing people's continued faith in PM Narendra Modi and the party. Asserting that NDA is likely to return to power in the union territory of Puducherry, he expressed confidence that the BJP-led alliance would emerge strongly in Kerala and Tamil Nadu.

The counting of votes for all five Assemblies—West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Kerala, and Assam—will take place on May 4.

Polls were conducted in a single phase in Assam, Kerala, Puducherry, and Tamil Nadu, while West Bengal saw two phases of polling on April 23 and 29.

On April 9, Assam, Kerala, and Puducherry went to the polls, while Tamil Nadu voted

on April 23.

"Beyond exit polls, all of us who worked in the election campaign this time in the five States (four States and one union territory) are confident that the BJP will retain power in Assam and that, for the first time in a long period, West Bengal is heading for a major change," Pradhan said.

Speaking to reporters, the union education minister said there is significant anti-incumbency against the TMC Government in West Bengal due to alleged misgovernance, appeasement politics, and corruption.

"The people of West Bengal are reposing their faith in the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the policies of the BJP and the leadership of the State BJP. I am confident there will be a change of Government in West Bengal," he added.

Pradhan said that, in all probability, the NDA (All India NR Congress-BJP alliance) will retain power in Puducherry.



Venugopal emerges as key driver as UDF surges ahead in Kerala 2026 polls: Survey

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) appears to have gained a decisive edge in the Kerala Assembly elections, with senior leader KC Venugopal emerging as a central figure shaping the electoral narrative, according to the 'Poll Mantra' exit survey.

The survey points to a clear momentum shift in the State, projecting the UDF to secure a comfortable majority with an estimated vote share of

38.5 per cent. The ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF) is projected at 33.4 per cent, while the NDA is expected to retain a stable base at 20.2 per cent.

In terms of seats, the UDF is forecast to win between 88 and 92 seats in the 140-member Assembly—well above the majority mark of 70. The LDF, led by Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, is projected to see a significant drop, with estimates ranging from 42 to 46 seats.

The survey highlights what it describes as a "structured shift" rather than a simple electoral swing. The UDF is



seen dominating the Malabar region while expanding its lead in Central Kerala. Although Travancore remains competitive, the

report suggests it may not be enough to offset the broader Statewide trend. Signs of anti-incumbency against the ruling front are also evident.

Leadership perception appears to have played a crucial role in shaping voter sentiment. Venugopal leads the influence chart with a rating of 21.4 per cent, followed by Vijayan at 18.6 per cent and Opposition Leader VD Satheesan at 16.2 per cent. Other Congress figures, including Shashi Tharoor and Shafi Parambil, are also noted as significant contributors to the UDF's campaign narrative.

In the race for the chief ministerial preference, Satheesan narrowly leads with 21.2 per cent, just ahead

of Vijayan at 20.5 per cent, while Venugopal follows with 17.8 per cent.

The survey also points to a "packed middle" tier in leadership preferences. Leaders such as KK Shailaja, Ramesh Chennithala, and Rajeev Chandrasekhar are each seen garnering support in the 10.5 per cent–11.2 per cent range.

This suggests that while the UDF benefits from multiple prominent faces, the LDF's appeal remains largely centered around the incumbent chief minister.



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Order Order

SC takes suo motu cognisance of delay in approval of resolution plans by NCLT

Terming the situation "grim", the Supreme Court has taken suo motu cognisance of the delay in approval of resolution plans by the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) benches.

A resolution plan is a statutory proposal under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) designed to revive a distressed company (corporate debtor) through restructuring or takeover.

A bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and KV Viswanathan on Wednesday also flagged the shortage of manpower and infrastructure in the NCLT benches across the country. The bench said the issue needed to be addressed on a war footing, otherwise the purpose of enacting the IBC would stand frustrated.

It directed that the matter be placed before Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant for assigning it to an appropriate bench.

The bench perused the report placed before it by the NCLT principal bench, as per which 383 applications were awaiting approval of the resolution plans across the country, with delays ranging from over one month to over 700 days. The top court passed the order while hearing two pleas against a 2023 order passed by the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT).



I-PAC director Vinesh Chandel gets bail in money laundering case

A Delhi court on Thursday granted bail to I-PAC co-founder and director Vinesh Chandel in a money laundering case linked to an alleged coal scam in West Bengal.

Additional Sessions Judge Amit Bansal noted that the Enforcement Directorate (ED) has not opposed the bail plea. Justice Bansal, however, imposed several bail conditions. A detailed order is awaited.

Earlier on April 14, the court had allowed the ED to quiz Chandel in its custody for 10 days, saying there are reasons to believe that he was actively involved in processes and activities connected with the generation, diversion and possession of proceeds of crime worth several crores. The ED arrested Chandel on April 13 after questioning.



Man acquitted in 26/11 terror case denied police clearance: HC



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court has said the police kept in mind the larger interest of public safety and national security while rightly refusing a clearance certificate to Fahim Ansari, acquitted in the 26/11 terror attack case, to ply an autorickshaw for livelihood.

The court has considered the confidential intelligence report submitted by the police, which "prima facie" indicates that the possibility of Ansari indulging in similar activities cannot be ruled out, a bench of Justices AS Gadgarkar and RR Bhonsale said in the judgment on Wednesday.

"We find no reason to differ with the opinion of the Government authorities nor can any fault be found with it," said the HC order, a copy of which was made available on Thursday.

The certificate to Ansari was refused in the backdrop of his criminal antecedents in a "reasonable manner and in

the larger interest of public safety and national security," it added.

Ansari filed the plea in January last year, seeking the police clearance certificate for the purpose of securing a public service vehicle badge, which is required to drive an autorickshaw for commercial purposes.

He said his arrest and trial in the 26/11 terror attacks case should not be used as a ground to bar him from availing public amenities and opportunities.

The Government had opposed the plea, claiming that the policy guidelines governing the police character verification clearly mandate that a person with a serious criminal background and with a prior conviction must be issued an adverse remark.

It also submitted a confidential note containing certain sensitive information/official intelligence communication against Ansari, based on which the certificate was refused to him.



SC slams Centre over airfare regulation plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday pulled up the Centre for not filing its affidavit on a petition which sought regulatory guidelines to control the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfare and ancillary charges imposed by private airlines in India.

A bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta asked the Centre to file an application along with an affidavit giving reasons for why the affidavit has not been filed and why further time was sought for it.

On November 17 last year, the top court sought responses from the Centre and others on a plea by social activist S Laxminarayanan, who sought a robust and independent regulator that ensures transparency and passenger protection across the civil aviation sector.

As soon as the hearing commenced on Thursday, the counsel appearing for the petitioner said no reply has been filed by the Centre yet. The Centre's counsel referred to the evolving situation in the Middle East. "What is this? What prevents



you from filing an affidavit," the bench asked. The Centre's counsel said they were contemplating framing rules.

"You file an affidavit and place everything on record. Why can't you file an affidavit? What is this stand of the Union? Three times we have granted you time," the bench said.

The Centre's counsel requested that three weeks time be granted to file the affidavit. The bench refused to grant three weeks time and said the affidavit be filed next week.



"You file your affidavit and say whatever you want to say. Your affidavit must come by next Friday (May 8)," the bench said.

In its order, the bench said despite the fact that notice was issued on the petition on November 17 last year and thereafter time was granted to the respondents to file the affidavit, "till date no affidavit has been filed".

It said today also the counsel representing the Centre has sought some more time. "We are not willing to accept the request. Let an appro-

priate application along with an affidavit giving reasons for why affidavit has not been filed and why further time is being sought, be filed within a week. List again on May 11," the bench said.

On February 23, the Centre told the apex court that the Ministry of Civil Aviation was actively considering the issues raised in the plea.

While hearing the matter on January 19, the top court said it would interfere with the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfares and flagged the exorbitant rise during festivals. The top court had termed the exorbitant rise of airfares by the airlines as "exploitation" and asked the Centre and the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) to file their replies on the plea.

In November last year, it had issued notices to the Centre, the DGCA and the Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India seeking their responses on the plea.

The plea claimed that all private airlines have, without any credible justification, reduced the free check-in baggage allowance for economy class passengers from 25 kg to 15 kg, "thereby converting what was

earlier part of the ticketed service into a new revenue stream".

It said the "new policy of permitting only a single piece for check-in and the absence of any rebate, compensation or benefit to passengers who do not avail themselves of check-in baggage demonstrates the arbitrary and discriminatory nature of the measure".

The plea claimed that currently, no authority has the power to review or cap airfares or ancillary fees, allowing the airlines to exploit consumers through hidden charges and unpredictable pricing.

It said the "unregulated, opaque and exploitative conduct of airlines manifesting in arbitrary fare hikes, unilateral reduction of services, absence of on-ground grievance redressal and unjustified dynamic pricing algorithms directly infringes upon citizens' fundamental rights to equality, freedom of movement and life with dignity".

It said the absence of regulatory safeguards results in arbitrary fare hikes, especially during festivals or weather disruptions, which disproportionately harm poor and last-minute travellers.

SC reserves order on Congress leader Pawan Khera's plea for anticipatory bail

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday reserved its order on a plea of Congress leader Pawan Khera seeking anticipatory bail in a case registered against him related to allegations that Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's wife possessed multiple passports and undisclosed properties abroad.

A bench of justices JK Maheshwari and AS Chandurkar reserved its decision on the plea after the Congress leader submitted that if he doesn't get anticipatory bail in a registered case



against him, then the very purpose of pre-arrest bail is gone.

Senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi, appearing for Khera, said the allegations against him are a matter of trial and it was not necessary to humiliate him by arrest.

He submitted that out of the total sections invoked against him, some are bailable while others don't require his arrest.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Assam Government, opposed the plea and said Khera showed fake and doctored copies of passports of the chief minister's wife.

He said Khera has been absconding and releasing videos and all the allegations about the chief minister's wife holding multiple citizenships are false.

Khera has challenged the April 24 order of the Gauhati High Court refusing to grant him anticipatory bail.

Muslim reservation ordinance lapsed in 2014: Maharashtra Govt to HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Government has told the Bombay High Court that a 2014 ordinance granting 5 per cent reservation to Muslims lapsed the same year, and hence a GR issued in February this year has not, per se, scrapped any quota to the community.

The state submitted its affidavit last week in response to a petition filed by advocate Syed Ejaz Naqvi, challenging the February 17 Government resolution (GR) that allegedly cancelled the 5 per cent reservation to the Muslim community in

Government jobs and education.

A bench of justices RI Chagla and Advait Sethna is likely to take up the plea for hearing on May 4.

Naqvi had termed the Government's decision as "racial discrimination" and claimed it was violative of the Constitution and against the interests of the Muslim community.

The affidavit, filed by the Social Justice and Special Assistance Department, however, refuted the "unfounded, baseless, and reckless allegations of racial discrimination" made in the petition against the State Government. "There is no discrimination, nor any provisions of the



constitution or any other laws are violated as no reservation can continue without statutory backing," the Government's affidavit said.

It said the petition was miscon-

ceived, devoid of merits, and liable to be dismissed as it proceeds on incorrect assumptions of fact and that the 2014 ordinance has lapsed.

As per the affidavit, the February 17 GR was "legal, valid, and issued in consonance with statutory provisions".

The Government said the July 2014 ordinance providing 5 per cent reservation of seats to Muslims in educational institutions and Government jobs lapsed in December the same year and was never replaced by any valid legislation thereafter.

"Consequently, no enforceable right survives or can be claimed on the basis of the said ordinance," it said.

SC directs Allahabad HC on senior's pension case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Coming to the rescue of a senior citizen suffering from cancer, the Supreme Court on Thursday asked the Allahabad High Court to grant an urgent hearing to his plea regarding pension and post-retiral benefits that has been pending for the last nine years.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi asked the High Court to consider the 77-year-old man's case on a sympathetic basis and give an out-of-turn hearing.

The top court was hearing a plea filed by one Ram Shanker who submitted that the prolonged delay in adjudication of his claim result-



ed in the violation of his fundamental rights under Articles 14 and 21 of the Constitution.

Shanker, who was employed in UP Government service, in his plea contended that "pension is not a bounty" but a vested right of an employee and forms an integral part of the right to livelihood under Article 21 of the Constitution.

The petitioner rendered service from June 1, 1970 to May 28, 1985. He later joined the Gas Authority of India Ltd.

High Court orders preservation of Sunjay Kapur's assets

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday directed preservation of the assets of late Sunjay Kapur, ruling that all "suspicious circumstances" raised by the industrialist's children from his marriage with actor Karisma Kapoor have to be completely removed by his third wife, Priya Kapur, before the acceptance of his purported last will.

Justice Jyoti Singh passed the interim order on an application filed by Karisma Kapoor's children to restrain Priya Kapur from alienating their father's assets, reportedly worth ₹30,000 crore. The interim application was filed in a suit by the children, challenging their late father's purported will of his assets.

"Having heard and on examination of the material on record, I have the considered view that all legitimate suspicious circumstances raised by the plaintiffs will have to be completely removed by defendant number one (Priya Kapur) before the document is accepted as the last will," the judge



said. "Plaintiffs have made out a prima-facie case that the assets which are subject matter need to be protected, preserved, pending disposal of the suit," she added. Justice Singh ordered that the equity shareholdings in the three Indian companies of the deceased cannot be changed and also restrained the disposal of his personal effects, including artwork.

The court said if the assets are not preserved and Priya Kapur ultimately fails to prove the validity and genuineness of the will, the deceased's children from his marriage with Karisma Kapoor — his second wife — and his mother Rani Kapur would be deprived of their legitimate shares.

SC defers to May 8 hearing on PIL alleging banking fraud by Anil Ambani-led ADAG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday deferred to May 8 the hearing on a PIL alleging large-scale banking fraud involving the Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group and its firms.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi was hearing the PIL filed by former bureaucrat EAS Sarma seeking a court-monitored investigation into alleged loan frauds exceeding ₹40,000 crore by the Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group (ADAG) firms led by Anil

Ambani. At the outset, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the CBI and the Enforcement Directorate, said the two central probe agencies have filed fresh status reports in pursuance of directions issued on March 23 in the case.

"The CBI and the ED have filed status reports. The kingpin has not been arrested. Anil Ambani was identified as the kingpin. But nothing has been done yet," lawyer Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the PIL petitioner, said.

"I cannot respond as to



why 'X' or 'Y' is not arrested. We have filed our status reports," the solicitor general said.

Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Anil Ambani, urged the bench to

accord him a hearing for half-an-hour as he has something to say which has not been apprised to any court so far.

"Before taking cognisance of (status) reports, we will

also hear you," the CJI said, adding that the court ordered a probe to ensure transparency and impartiality in the ongoing investigations.

Earlier, the bench expressed displeasure over the "reluctance" shown by the CBI and the ED in probing the alleged large-scale banking fraud involving ADAG and its firms.

It had directed the CBI and the ED to conduct a "fair, dispassionate, transparent, and time-bound" investigation into the matter.

The bench also directed all financial institutions con-

cerned to "render full cooperation to the ED".

It also permitted the central probe agencies to approach it in case there is any reluctance on the part of other Government bodies in extending cooperation to them. Mehta informed the bench that an SIT, in pursuance of an earlier order, had been constituted comprising senior ED officers and financial experts from the banking sector.

He said the probe agencies, so far, attached assets worth ₹15,000 crore and also arrested four persons, including a few senior officials.

education and training, resulting in erroneous and inconsistent decisions.

The petition drafted by advocate Ashwani Dubey stated that the issue was dealt with by the Allahabad High Court, but its direction has not been implemented in letter and spirit to date.

The present system causes widespread and continuing injury to citizens by subjecting the adjudication of land disputes to revenue officers without legal background, resulting in arbitrary, inconsistent and erroneous decisions.



claimed that non-qualified legal professionals were deciding land disputes.

The plea submitted that nearly 66 per cent of civil cases were related to land disputes, and the key lacuna was that they were being adjudicated by officers lacking formal legal

EX-CJI KHANNA APPOINTED AS MEDIATOR TO RESOLVE SURAT BUSINESSMAN DISPUTE



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday appointed former chief justice of India Sanjiv Khanna as sole mediator to resolve a dispute involving prominent businessman Ashokbhai Haribhai Gajera and others in a case linked to textile market projects at Surat.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi was hearing an appeal filed by Gajera and two others against the March 11 order of the Gujarat High Court.

The High Court had dismissed a batch of petitions filed by Gajera and others seeking to quash an FIR involving allegations of siphoning off ₹1,900 crore and forging documents to illegally reduce a partner's shareholding.

The CJI-led bench heard the arguments advanced by senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi on behalf of Gajera assailing the High Court verdict.

Editor's TAKE

Exit polls signal the mood, not the mandate

Exit polls offer an early glimpse of the Assembly election outcomes, but conflicting projections – especially in West Bengal - highlight their limits

As the elections draw to a close, one of the most eagerly awaited events is the announcement of the election results. But, before that, exit polls are released, which help sustain the election momentum and provide fodder for the talking heads. Within hours of the last vote being cast, the pollsters are out with the exit polls, and most of us believe them to be the results, though many times they have been proved wrong. Yet, they are widely watched television programmes across the nation. The exit polls are conducted by several psephologists which often differ from one another, giving mixed signals to viewers. But the nation is hooked, as it cannot wait for the final counting day, just a few days ahead. This time around, the show is no different.

The broad trends emerging from the “poll of polls” for the recently held Assembly elections suggest a familiar pattern: incumbency holding firm in some regions, while anti-incumbency outmaneuvering the ruling party elsewhere. Yet, exit polls can at best predict the general electoral mood, as they are an imperfect science. On the face of it, the projections appear largely in line with political expectations. In Assam, most pollsters have forecast a comfortable return for the BJP-led alliance. Similarly, in Puducherry, the AINRC-led NDA is expected to retain power, reinforcing the perception of stability in the Union Territory. Exit polls are generally more accurate if the contest is one-sided, but if it is a close contest, their predictions can go haywire.

In Tamil Nadu, most exit polls point towards a second innings for the DMK, suggesting that the electorate may have endorsed continuity over change. However, the emergence of actor Vijay's TVK has been seen as a spoiler for the DMK and may lead to a hung Assembly, according to some predictions. But it is different story in Kerala which appears to be poised for a cyclical shift, with most exit polls predicting a comeback for the Congress-led UDF after two consecutive terms of the LDF, aligning with the state's long-standing tradition of alternating governments. Meanwhile, West Bengal remains the most keenly observed state. While several exit polls give the BJP an edge, others project a victory for the Trinamool Congress.

Despite these seemingly coherent narratives, the reliability of exit polls remains a matter of debate. Their track record in India has been mixed at best. Methodological limitations – ranging from small or unrepresentative samples to urban bias and respondent hesitancy – put a question mark on their credibility. Unlike in the West, it is a challenge to capture the diversity of India's electorate – the interplay of caste, class, and regional factors – in small sample sizes which makes precise forecasting exceedingly difficult. One would need the sample size to be really huge and diverse to nullify these biases. Do exit polls serve a constructive democratic purpose? Proponents argue that they enhance transparency. Critics, however, contend that they risk shaping perceptions prematurely, influencing market behaviour and building political narratives. It is better to wait for the counting day as the final word rests with the voters. May 4 is not very far away after all!

America's deadly divide over firearms

Despite recurring mass shootings and even assassination attempts on its presidents, the gun control debate in the United States remains one of the most polarising fault lines in public life, shaped by ideology, identity, and political calculation



BHOPINDER SINGH

Traditionally, Republicans are more opposed to gun control laws than the Democrats, owing to differences in cultural identity of respective cadres, geographical psychographics, and also the urban-rural split (or the coast-line-hinterland “divide”). The Republican heartland is essentially the white-dominated “redneck” country, where people go hunting and have self-defence traditions. Therefore, the all-powerful National Rifle Association (NRA) has aligned itself with Republican ranks to pursue its agenda. The Second Amendment to the Constitution is interpreted contrastingly by Republicans and Democrats. The line “A well-regulated Militia, being necessary to the security of a free State, the right of the people to keep and bear Arms, shall not be infringed” - herein, the word “militia” is decoded by Republicans as implying individuals.

Today, Americans own 46 per cent of the world's civilian-owned firearms. It has been statistically proven that firearm ownership increases the risk of firearm homicide, suicide, and even impulsive lethality. As per the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), this leads to 45,000-48,000 gun-related deaths annually. All counter-arguments that firearms provide safety are humbug, as data show that firearm ownership puts individuals and their families at higher risk of injury and death. It is well established that bearing weapons tends to trigger aggressive thoughts and actions. So why do Republicans still oppose gun control laws? Besides the interpretation of the Second Amendment, there is also an unmistakable racial undertone to that position, wherein white supremacist/majoritarian groups (core Republican base) are inherently and overwhelmingly opposed to gun laws.

Former President of the United States, Ronald Reagan, was a classic Republican (with his cowboy image), like Donald Trump today. In 1981, an actress-obsessed lunatic shot at President Ronald Reagan to impress the said actress and catch her attention. Ironically, the shooter was a white male who had registered as a Republican earlier. The shooter's action was not a political act, but a delusional act driven by psychological impulse. Yet, despite being hit and having a narrow escape after surgery, Reagan did not budge from the core Republican stance. He argued, “It's a nasty truth, but those who seek to inflict harm are not fazed by gun control laws. I happen to know this from personal experience”.

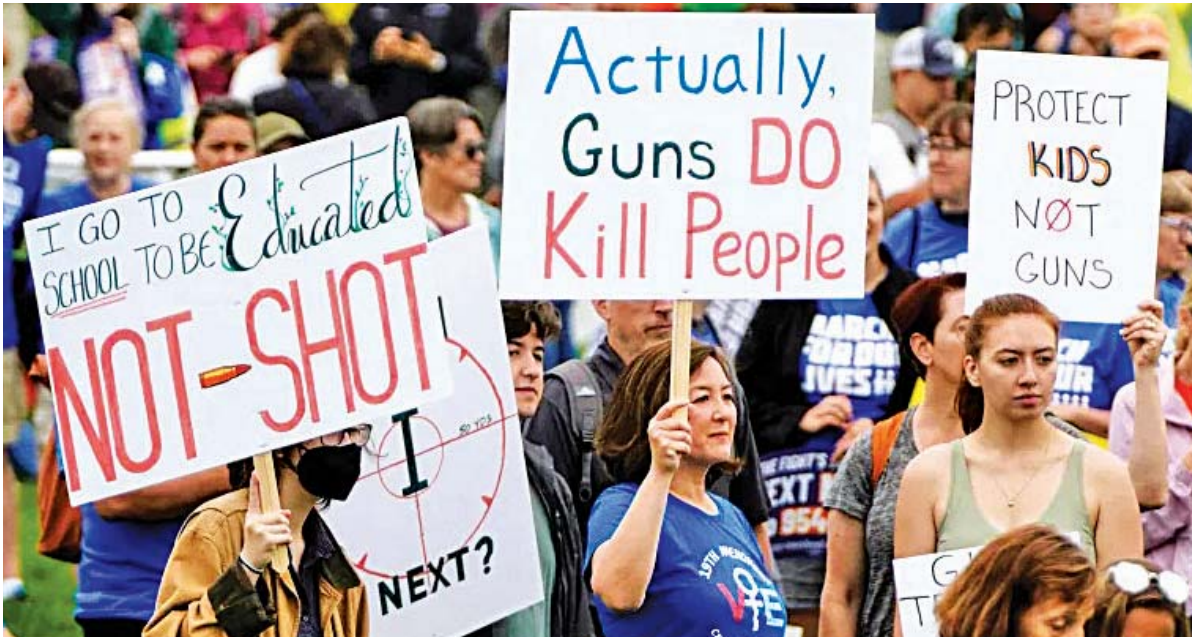
IT IS IMPORTANT TO NOTE THAT MOST ATTACKS CONDUCTED HAVE NOT EMANATED FROM THE SOCIETAL TYPOGRAPHIES THAT HAVE BEEN FEARMONGERED BY POLITICIANS LIKE TRUMP

The writer, a military veteran, is a former Lt Governor of Andaman & Nicobar Islands and Puducherry

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The Pioneer



Most likely, the shrewd politician would have sensed that any strengthening of anti-gun laws would have gone against his political base. However, once out of office and seeing the real-time fate of his Press Secretary, James Brady (left permanently disabled), in the same shootout, Reagan supported the anti-gun Brady Bill, thereby building a bipartisan consensus on the issue. It marked a significant turning point in US gun policy.

The US has had a violent past of presidential assassinations, with figures such as Abraham Lincoln, William McKinley, and JF Kennedy. Many more have survived assassination attempts. Whenever such instances occurred, the deeply partisan issue of gun laws erupted, only to subside thereafter to familiar positions of disagreement between Republicans and Democrats.

The most recent addition to presidential assassination attempts involves the current incumbent, Donald Trump, who has faced multiple attempts on his life. Trump was first fired upon at a Pennsylvania campaign rally in July 2024. Later, in September 2024, Secret Service agents spotted a gunman concealed in the bushes of his golfing club in Florida. Most recently, at the White House Correspondents' Association Dinner in Washington, a major security scare was averted as the supposed “lone wolf” could not reach the presidential dais.

But Trump is a 24-hour politician who seizes every opportunity to sharpen his polarising image and invest in personal bravado, as opposed to making restorative changes towards tackling rampant gun misuse in American society. In the

Pennsylvania shooting attempt, he struck a gladiator-like fist-pump pose. Now, post the latest attempt, he postured “muscularity” by insisting that he did not want to leave the place and that he “fought like hell to stay, but it was protocol”. This incident may be political gold for Trump personally to revive his sagging popularity following the unpopular Iran war, but it could also be yet another lost opportunity to make wiser decisions on gun laws.

Trump should show humility and sensitivity on the issue of gun violence by rising above partisan positions if he is to make America – and Americans – truly safe. Already, Trump's “us-versus-them” narrative has dangerously divided Americans and made many feel deeply isolated, discriminated against, and even targeted. There is a disturbing cause-and-effect relationship that can be established between a tense society and easy access to weapons. But neither is Trump expected to lower his xenophobic and polarising rhetoric, nor is he expected to draft progressive legislation that rises above partisan positions, even if the same is tantamount to making America safer.

It is important to note that most attacks conducted have not emanated from the societal typographies that have been fearmongered by politicians like Trump. If anything, very often these “lone wolves” hail from sections of society that are encouraged by his policies. As Trump's predecessor at the White House, Joe Biden, famously said, “Enough prayers. Time for action”. But it is unlikely that Trump will drive any positive action, despite this incident.

PIC TALK



Young girls perform a traditional dance during the KVS Regional Sports Meet 2026 in Dharamshala, Himachal Pradesh.

PHOTO: PTI

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Aunty: From casual address to cultural stereotype



KAJLEEN KAUR

2ND OPINION

Recently, a UK employment tribunal ruled in favour of an Indian-origin healthcare assistant and awarded her approx ₹1.7 lakh in compensation after a colleague repeatedly called her “aunty” against her wishes. It was quoted that using it when unwantedly creates an offensive environment, and constitutes harassment, age and sex discrimination and carries a negative social impact.

Aunty, a social label, reflects a generational gap and is now taken to be a ‘hostile’ and ridiculed manner of addressing a lady. It is actually a spoiled form of “aunt,” which, according to any English dictionary, means “father's/mother's sister.” But in our society, it has a filthy meaning of not being young anymore, with its use further deteriorating to refer to “middle-class mentality”. In common parlance, it refers to an ageing woman, even

“not-so-elderly,” if she is married, or, surely, when she is a mother, or if she chooses to dress in ethnic clothing. Social media and memes have additionally reinforced it from a gesture of respect to a subject of humour.

All women of 40-plus age or even in their late 30s have to face the trauma of the uncalled-for transition to the new age group, and thereby to the unfriendly sobriquet. It does take some time to sink in, and every lady in India can well relate it to the famous lines from an old TV serial, “Aunty Mat Kaho Na”. The initial stages of the shock begin with substantial time spent in front of the mirror, checking for any visible wrinkles on the face, salt and pepper hair, or any such trait in physical appearance that has pushed them into this new ugly stamping. This is then followed by efforts to improve skin care routines and maintain a good figure. The result is an extra slot of expenditure spent on the services of beauticians and gymsnasiums.

It's worth pondering what urges us to keep away from this branding. There is indeed an insecurity in joining the too-early and unwanted old-age league. In fact, in the contemporary world, even the actually elderly women are choosing to take up invasive cosmetic treatments like Botox, fillers, and hair transplants to manage to look young and, needless to say, not be referred to as Aunty. Moreover, a comparison with a little time ago in the 1990s, women were

mostly restricted to household chores and family care. There was a smaller proportion of the population consisting of women who were working, driving vehicles, and working out in gymnasiums or doing aerobics or swimming to maintain their physiques. The society was not even open to women with modern or western dressing, especially after marriage. So now, if women are working hard to keep themselves young, it is also for society to respect their choice and approve of their disapproval. A serious introspection of the situation, to the unrecognitive and offensive nature of the ‘Aunty title’, is needed, given its misogynistic relevance and social consequences, especially when it has been taken legally. We must understand that times, outlook of people, education, and society are all transforming. There is more acceptance and respect for people's opinions and the mental impact of any action.

As societies evolve and we strive for an inclusive culture, we should discard acts of personification, disrespect, and unhealthy communicative practices. Words may seem trivial, but they quietly shape attitudes, and changing them is often the first step towards changing mindsets. It can be replaced with more respectful, pleasing, and acceptable forms of address such as Madam and Sir.

The Pioneer SINCE 1865

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FROM CONVICT TO COUNSEL: SHOULD THE BAR OPEN?

The concerns raised by Congress MP R Sudha in her letter to President Droupadi Murmu deserve serious attention. Her appeal to cancel the enrolment of A G Perarivalan as an advocate has reignited a difficult but necessary debate on the limits of rehabilitation in cases involving grave national crimes.

Perarivalan was convicted in connection with the assassination of former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi, which deeply scarred the nation. In 1998, a TADA court sentenced him to death, a verdict upheld by the Supreme Court of India. Years later, prolonged delays in deciding his mercy petitions led the Court to commute his sentence to life imprisonment in 2014. In 2022, invoking its extraordinary powers under Article 142, the Court ordered his release, citing the extraordinary length of

incarceration and his conduct. Yet, this judicial relief was not an exoneration. The conviction stands; the gravity of the offence remains unchanged. The release was grounded in constitutional compassion, not a reassessment of guilt.

This raises a troubling question: how did a person convicted of such a heinous crime gain admission to a law university and subsequently enter the legal profession? Institutions typically require disclosure of criminal history. If such norms exist, were they applied uniformly in this instance?

The legal profession demands public trust. Rehabilitation must be balanced with ethical expectations, ensuring justice and mercy are both upheld and seen to be upheld.

AP THIRUVADI | CHENNAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Heatwave hardships of field workers

Extreme heat across the nation has made each passing day miserable for everyone. The government and administration have issued orders, especially for children and the elderly, to remain indoors between 11 am and 5 pm to minimise heatstroke and summer-related ailments. However, some professionals are compelled to work in scorching conditions, as their jobs involve meeting prospects to promote company products at the customer's convenience. They are often kept waiting for hours for just a few minutes of interaction with doctors. These professionals are pharmaceutical field workers and their middle management, popularly known as medical representatives and area managers.

Irrespective of uncomfortable and harsh weather, they must meet doctors to promote products. Often, they wear formal attire, including neckties, even in peak summer to remain presentable.

Although some are well paid, their job security depends heavily on performance. Despite daily risks and pressure, their concerns remain unheard. Lawmakers and authorities must recognise their struggles and consider safeguards for their safety, dignity, and job security.

SUNIL OKHADE | INDORE

Aviation sector in turbulence

India's aviation sector is once again navigating turbulence, and the warning signs are too stark to ignore. Aviation remains an inherently fragile business, as the collapse of Jet Airways so vividly demonstrated. The Federation of Indian Airlines has rightly flagged the unsustainable burden of aviation turbine fuel pricing, which continues to distort the sector's cost structure.

When input costs remain persistently elevated, airlines are left with limited levers. One predictable response is aggressive cost-cutting. This often manifests in reduced connectivity on marginal routes and a decline in passenger convenience, as witnessed during recent operational disruptions involving IndiGo. Such measures may offer short-term relief to balance sheets, but they gradually erode the overall quality of service.

More concerning is the long-term risk to safety and maintenance. Financial strain can lead to deferred investments in upkeep and training, posing systemic risks.

India's aviation growth cannot rely only on rising passenger numbers while ignoring structural inefficiencies. Rationalising ATF pricing and taxes is essential to ensure service reliability and passenger safety.

HARSH PAWARIA | ROHTAK

Exit Polls on shaky ground

The exit polls published after voting concluded across Tamil Nadu, Kerala, West Bengal, Assam, and Puducherry present projections so contradictory that careful reading is essential before treating them as political fact.

Tamil Nadu is where the confusion runs deepest. Most agencies project a DMK-led alliance victory with 125-160 seats, yet Axis My India gives TVK up to 120 seats, and VoteVibe gives AIADMK an outright edge. These are not marginal differences - they describe entirely different electoral outcomes. Kerala polls broadly agree on a UDF return after a decade. West Bengal projections suggest a possible BJP majority, potentially ending fifteen years of TMC rule, while Assam points comfortably towards BJP retention. History offers a sobering corrective. In the 2021 Assembly elections, all four leading agencies — Axis My India, C-Voter, Jan Ki Baat, and Today's Chanakya — got at least one state wrong. West Bengal was the standout failure, with polls severely underestimating TMC.

In 2024, major agencies predicted 350-400 Lok Sabha seats for the NDA; the alliance secured 293. Beyond numbers, exit polls shape perception. Without transparency, they remain expectation management.

A MYLSAMI | COIMBATORE

Chernobyl at 40: A disaster that refuses to end

From the damaged shell of Reactor 4 to the militarised exclusion zone, Chernobyl today is not a relic of the past but a warning in motion, where science struggles against uncertainty and institutions continue to manage dangers they cannot fully control



NILANTHA
ILANGAMUWA

The fundamental lesson of any tragedy that claims to teach something is simple: build a mechanism that prevents repetition. Yet history rarely behaves like a controlled experiment. It loops, mutates, and returns in altered form, often in places that insist they have already understood the lesson. Forty years ago, on a day like today, 26 April, Chernobyl tore through that assumption. It did not just expose a failed reactor design; it exposed how quickly institutions, states, and expertise bend under pressure, secrecy, and denial. Since then, new nations have formed, old ones have dissolved, and international bodies have rebranded themselves as guardians of “lessons learned”. And still, the core pattern persists: systems that acknowledge danger while continuing to reproduce it.

Chernobyl today is often framed as a resolved chapter. Reporting from the exclusion zone does not support that comfort. It is not closed. It has been contained, partially stabilised, and then reinserted into another instability: war. The New Safe Confinement, a \$1.5 billion structure meant to lock away reactor 4’s remains for a century-long decommissioning process, is already damaged by a drone strike. Engineers are no longer working only against decay and radiation, but against renewed physical attack. One senior engineer put it plainly: “You cannot tell radioactivity to stop being radioactive.” That is obvious physics. The problem is political systems that behave as if physics can be subordinated to urgency, conflict, or neglect.

Inside the reactor itself, the language used by scientists is stripped of sentiment. There is no room for metaphor when describing “corium — a mix of melted fuel, concrete, and metal formed in 2500°C heat”, or when describing spikes of neutron activity that still appear unpredictably. One researcher, Anatoly Doroshenko, who enters the structure to take measurements, describes his preparation in terms that are almost procedural rather than emotional: “You should be aware that everything is contaminated.” He adds, repeatedly, “you should control yourself.” The repetition is not stylistic; it is instruction. The work is not about courage; it is about limiting error in a place where error becomes physical consequence.

This is the same reactor where, as another account records, “the reactor flew” seconds after the AZ-5 shutdown button was pressed. The mechanism designed to stop the system instead accelerated its destruction. Systems fail not only through absence of control, but through control functions that behave unpredictably under stress. Forty years later, the most repeated claim in contemporary reporting is not about radiation itself, but about displacement. A recent New Scientist report states directly: “The biggest threat to Chernobyl is no longer radiation.” It continues: “The one-dimensional view of Chernobyl as a contaminated wasteland is wildly off the mark.” This matters because public memory tends to freeze the site into a single condition: a poisoned void. The reality is more unstable. Radiation has decayed unevenly, ecosystems have expanded, and wolves and moose move through zones where humans cannot safely remain for long periods. But stability here is conditional, dependent on maintenance, monitoring, funding, and above all, political access.

That political access has become the fragile point. The exclusion zone is now also militarised territory. Russian occupation in 2022 brought trench digging in contaminated soil, looting of laboratories, and the destruction of research continuity. One scientist described returning to his office to find it stripped, computers removed, and research interrupted mid-process. Another described it as “typical behaviour for a medieval army”, a phrase that is not literary but diagnostic: extraction without understanding value systems beyond immediate use.

El Pais documents the same rupture from a different angle, through lived memory inside the zone. A former worker recalls Russian soldiers asking: “Who has given you permission to live better than us?” It is not about Chernobyl, but about comparison systems embedded in modern conflict. The exclusion zone becomes a mirror for political grievance projected onto infrastructure, science, and ordinary survival. The city did not die; it was displaced, reoccupied by forest, then by soldiers, then by scientists again. Death here is not an event but a



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WHAT REMAINS
AFTER 40 YEARS IS
NOT RESOLUTION,
BUT LAYERED
INSTABILITY:
RADIOACTIVE
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REGARDLESS OF
HUMAN
CLASSIFICATION

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Why India’s children need more than just food



SARATH
GOPALAN

healthy children falling behind. Not because of the virus, but because of everything that came after it. The World Health Organization tells us that 90 per cent of brain development occurs before the age of five, making the early years the single greatest opportunity we have to shape a child’s cognitive, emotional, and social future. The neural connections formed during this window strengthen learning, language, memory, and resilience for life. Getting nutrition right in this period is one of the most powerful investments we can make. Micronutrients such as iron, zinc, and selenium, often described as neuronutrients, are essential for healthy brain development and function. Yet the data tells us a troubling story. Iron deficiency alone affects approximately 50 per cent of children under five in India (NFHS-5). Anaemia was recorded in 67.1 per cent of children aged under five, up from the previous survey. Recent evidence, including nationally representative analyses of children aged 12-59 months, found that over 60 per cent had micronutrient deficiencies, with or without anaemia. This points to a far wider nutritional gap than haemoglobin counts alone reveal.

Docosahexaenoic acid (DHA), an omega-3 fatty acid, supports brain architecture, memory formation, and visual development. Choline, another essential nutrient, is now considered essential for brain development. When mothers consume choline during pregnancy, it supports healthy gene activity, cell structure, and the growth of key brain regions, including those responsible for memory and thinking. These nutrients are not optional additions to a child’s diet; they are foundational to their potential. The most important nutritional intervention in a child’s life begins before birth. Brain development starts in the foetal stage, and a mother’s nutritional status directly shapes the neural foundation her child carries into the world. DHA supports neural connectivity in utero; iron and folic acid supplementation during pregnancy reduce the risk of low birth weight and developmental delay. Yet only 44 per cent of pregnant women in India consumed iron-folic acid supplements for the recommended 180 or more days (NFHS-5), a gap that represents an enormous and addressable opportunity.

This is why investing in adolescent girls is an investment in the next generation. A well-nourished girl becomes a well-nourished mother, and a well-nourished mother



gives her child the best possible start. With 59 per cent of adolescent girls in India anaemic (NFHS-5), prioritising this group through schools, community programmes, and targeted supplementation is one of the most effective interventions in the entire continuum of care.

Although nutrition is important, brain development requires two parallel inputs: nutritional adequacy and emotional-social stimulation. The pandemic illustrated this powerfully. UNICEF estimates that one in seven children globally experienced significant developmental or learning loss during COVID-19, not primarily from illness, but from the withdrawal of peer interaction, conversation, and play. Screens

replaced human connection, and language, motor, and social development suffered.

Responsive caregiving, verbal interaction, tactile engagement, and a stimulating environment are neurologically formative and are essential to healthy brain architecture. Early childhood programmes that integrate both nutritional support and developmental stimulation produce outcomes that neither can achieve alone. India’s programme architecture is well placed to act on this.

Programmes like POSHAN Abhiyaan and PM POSHAN already reach millions of mothers and young children across the country. Initiatives like POSHAN Pakhwada demonstrate the power of sustained, community-level mobilisation around nutrition. The delivery architecture, which includes the anganwadi network, the front-line workforce, and community-level reach, is in place. The opportunity now is to deepen what that architecture delivers.

With the right training and support, they can expand their role from tracking physical growth to also guiding parents on early stimulation, responsive caregiving, and child development practices. Integrating the WHO and UNICEF Nurturing Care Framework, which connects nutrition, health, safety, early learning, and caregiving into a coherent whole, offers a clear and scientific roadmap for this evolution. It moves the goal from simply feeding children to helping them truly thrive.

Nutrition in early childhood is among the highest-return investments a nation can make. When children receive what their developing brains need — the right micronutrients, the right caregiving environment, and the right stimulation - the dividends are lifelong: stronger learners, more productive workers, and a more resilient society.

India has the ambition of Viksit Bharat. It has the systems. It has the science. What this moment calls for is a shared commitment to treating early childhood nutrition not as a welfare line item, but as the foundation on which everything else is built.

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ABHISHEK
PRATAP SINGH

KAUSTUBH
TRIPATHI

When South Korean President Lee Jae-myung landed in New Delhi on April 19, he carried the weight of eight lost years. The last state visit by a South Korean leader was President Moon Jae-in (2018). This gap spanned a pandemic, the Ukraine crisis, the Iran war, global supply chain disruptions, and emerging geopolitical shifts in Asia. This makes the summit not a routine renewal of ties but a deliberate act of ‘strategic recalibration’ between India and South Korea.

This visit did not come in any geopolitical vacuum. Its immediate diplomatic genealogy traces to the G7 Summit in Kananaskis, Canada (June 2025), where Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Lee held their first bilateral meeting and agreed on cooperation in commerce, investment, technology, and shipbuilding. They met again on the sidelines of the G20

Summit in Johannesburg (November 2025), where Modi personally extended the invitation. In addition, the sixth India-South Korea Foreign Policy and Security Dialogue (FPSD) held in Seoul (February 2026) provided a foundation for this visit, leading to an upgrade in bilateral relations.

Both India and South Korea are mid-sized, significant powers with large economies. India, now the world’s fifth largest, and South Korea, the twelfth, are navigating a disruptive global order marked by economic protectionism, trade weaponisation, and rising power assertiveness. In the words of Prime Minister Modi, both share commitments to democratic values, the rule of law, and a stable Indo-Pacific outlook. The shift in the relationship is not sentimental but structural and contextual.

The composition of the South Korean delegation makes this visit distinct. President Lee arrived with over 200 individuals — ministers, senior officials, and business leaders representing key industrial sectors. This does not appear to be a delegation assembled merely for protocol; rather, it reflects a market-entry force. When industry leaders in semiconductors, shipbuilding, and defence manufacturing accompany the President, the signal is clear: Seoul is here to build a long-term presence and strengthen bilateral relations.

The economic context explains the ‘why’. The Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), signed in 2010, has delivered growth but also accumulated trade imbalances. The two sides have now committed to



upgrading CEPA, identifying asymmetries, expanding market access, and aligning it with evolving global supply chain realities. Bilateral trade has grown from \$14 billion in 2010 to \$27 billion in 2025, with Indian imports at around \$18.5 billion. India expects that CEPA 2.0 will address non-tariff barriers, boost services exports, and rebalance trade flows.

The two sides have signed 25 agreements focusing on enhancing steel exports from India, establishing a new Steel Dialogue, setting up Korean Industrial Townships, and joint production of anti-aircraft guns and missiles. Additional agreements include AI research, science and technology education, space exploration, digital payments, sports, and cultural exchanges.

An India-Korea Business Forum at Bharat

Mandapam brought together industry leaders to translate summit commitments into tangible investments. The digital payment interoperability initiative could facilitate flows for small and medium enterprises, often the last beneficiaries of such agreements. New platforms have been launched to streamline financial flows and boost industrial links, including the India-Korea Financial Forum (IKFF) and an Industrial Cooperation Committee. The aim is to achieve \$50 billion in bilateral trade by 2030, with a focus on technology, resources, and long-term supply chain stability.

Cooperation in the semiconductor sector deserves special attention. India is advancing its Semiconductor Mission 2.0, backed by a ₹76,000 crore incentive programme. India is actively seeking South Korean support to achieve its semiconductor ambitions. The India-Korea Digital Bridge (IKDB) provides an institutional channel to integrate India’s manufacturing incentives with South Korea’s technological strengths. Under the ‘plus one’ strategy, India is positioning itself as a global base for assembling, testing, marking, and packaging semiconductors.

This is not a one-way arrangement. While India seeks technology and capital, it offers South Korea market diversification, reduced dependence on Chinese exports, and a skilled workforce. An India-Korea chip corridor could reduce global dependence on Taiwan-centric fabrication - a goal aligned with broader strategic interests.

In shipbuilding, South Korea remains a global leader in LNG carriers, container vessels, and off-

shore platforms. The Comprehensive Framework for Shipbuilding and Maritime Logistics outlines partnerships in greenfield clusters, upgrading Indian yards, and building a \$25 billion pipeline for 400 vessels. To address shortages of specialised maritime engineers, both sides have agreed to train 10,000 engineers through KOICA. For India, Korean capital and expertise align directly with its Viksit Bharat 2047 vision.

India provides land, labour, and a growing market, while South Korea brings technology, training standards, and global contracts. This partnership also carries strategic weight, especially as West Asian tensions disrupt shipping routes through the Strait of Hormuz.

The India-ROK Joint Strategic Vision document signals that both nations view this relationship in civilisational and strategic terms. Rabindranath Tagore’s “Lamp of the East” for Korea reminds us that this partnership has deep historical roots. The long-term agenda of this summit aims to transform this legacy into a powerful engine for industrial growth and strategic cooperation.

By converging their strengths, India and South Korea are forging a forward-looking partnership, turning diplomacy into tangible outcomes. In the illumination of the East, both nations stand together as trusted partners.

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BLASÉ CAPITAL

CRUDE @ \$120-125

An illustration featuring several black oil barrels with yellow flame logos and the word 'OIL' in white. They are positioned on a dark blue background with a glowing, digital price chart showing fluctuating lines.

For a brief period yesterday, global crude oil prices went over \$125 a barrel, and settled at \$120. Thus, they are up by 70 per cent compared to what they traded at before the Iran war. The last time we saw crude at this level was in the summer of 2022, when tight supplies due to the Russia-Ukraine war, fears of Iran-like and US-like disruptions by Russia, possible production cuts by OPEC+ members, and price rise by Saudi Arabia, a crucial producer, wreaked havoc in the markets. Before that, during the Great Recession and Financial Crisis of 2008, the prices had almost reached \$150. With an aggressive stance shown by the US to keep the Strait of Hormuz under control, petulant Iran's counter to not step back, and break down in talks between the two has raised fresh fears of crude oil@\$150. It is the worst nightmare turning out to be true, even as there was some breathing space in the past two weeks. While producers may adjust, the consumer nations will pay a heavy price for the ongoing conflict, which may derail several economies by a few years in terms of growth and macro indicators.

What is surprising is how the two main actors and protagonists in the ongoing war have contributed to the price rise, and a shoot up in risk premiums. In the first few weeks, Iran held the world as a hostage, as it targeted the Strait of Hormuz, a major supply route. As tankers halted, and were forced to take the longer route via the Cape of Good Hope, prices surged, as did shipping and insurance costs. Later, the US, which decided that enough was enough, and intervened to sober down the prices in fact contributed more to the higher price levels. It tried to blockade Kharg Island, the key export port for Iran's crude, and other products, which implicitly restricted the flow of smuggled and illegal oil to several nations like China. Simultaneously, America decided to open up the Strait of Hormuz, using its warships and Navy, which somehow further choked the route, and brought supplies to a standstill. In essence, the one who wanted to help ended up exacerbating the issue. We are back to the initial countdown. In the first week or so, crude oil shot up to \$110, and now it is higher at \$120. Iran may be blamed for the former, but the US needs to take the rap for the latter.

According to an analyst quoted in a media report, "The breakdown of talks between the US and Iran, along with President (Donald) Trump reportedly rejecting Iran's proposal for a reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, has the market losing hope for any quick resumption in oil flows." Several experts have consistently maintained that even if the war ends, crude oil prices will remain much higher than the pre-war levels, or around \$90 a barrel. Thus, the risk premiums will remain high, higher now due to the war, and slightly-lower but high enough later due to possible disruptions. Indeed, the quoted price of crude oil has lost some of its relevance because some consumers are paying under-the-table premiums to re-route tankers on the high seas. The official prices, which vary as per nature of oil and locations, as well as in spot and futures, remain an indicator. One is not sure about the price China is paying for Iran's oil, and what is the price at which Russia is selling to the others. The fact is that the Russian oil, which was available at a discount before the war, commands a huge premium. Even smuggled oil may sell at higher-than-market prices, given the risks due to the intervention of the US Navy, and Iranian missiles.

Even as producers and consumers, along with the traders, analysts, policy-makers, and experts grapple with the fast-fluctuating oil prices, there are some significant long-term trends in the making, which will impact the prices in the future once the war ends. The first is the implementation of the new production formula by the OPEC producer nations, which was to be in place now but is delayed due to the war. This will prevent nations from over-producing, or at least aim to do so, as the limits and quotas will be under a strict formula. Thus, supplies may reduce from OPEC, which may keep prices high. As some experts contend, they may be lower than \$100 but much higher than the pre-war price of \$70. One is still not sure of the impact of the UAE leaving the OPEC group, and charting its independent energy trajectory. Some indicate that the nation may get closer to the US, which may influence global production and supplies. Others hint that the UAE wants to flex its muscle in the Middle East, and show that it is more powerful than Saudi Arabia. The dynamics between the independence of the UAE, and the new production formula of OPEC may play in unexpected ways. Couple this with America's aggressive intention to find more buyers for its oil, especially to lure India away from Russia and other sources. Russia will wish to sell more, and so will Iran, if the war ends well.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | MAY 1, 2026

BUSINESS

10

Divided Fed or fed up with Prez?

At possibly Powell's last meeting, politics dictates policy intent

It was almost 35 years ago, actually in 1992, when four members of the US Federal Reserve dissented against a majority policy decision. In effect, a third of the participants disagreed, three against a future indication, and one who wanted a reduction in interest rate. Although analysts are unwilling to give it a political twist, a part of the division, 8:4 of the 12 members, hints at a huge message to President Donald Trump. This month, Chair Jerome Powell may lose his seat, although he plans to continue as a member. Trump's loyalist, Kevin Warsh, will take over, and most likely toe the president's line to reduce the rate.

For almost 16 months, Trump has pommelled Powell to reduce rates faster, and the former is fed up with the decisions to maintain them in the recent past. Warsh, whose nomination is under review by the Senate but is likely to go through despite opposition related to the ongoing investigations against Powell, will surely push for rate cuts in the future. The three dissents, out of the four, hint that the existing members are unlikely to capitulate into submission, and may oppose the moves if the economic trends demand it. Thus, there are hints of politics at the Fed, which shows that their members too are fed up.

According to an analyst, "This (dissent) not only highlights the potential for more of the same in the coming months as a new Chair focused on changing the Fed takes over, but also the reality that the nearer term economic outlook remains highly uncertain given conflicting labour market, and economic growth signals against a backdrop of inflation that has been stuck at three per cent plus since the end

of 2023." In essence, he implies that many members may agree with Powell that a rate cut is not the right policy in the future.

One needs to understand the status of the dissenters, and the reasons for their disagreement to understand how the politics, and inter-personal differences will play out in the future. One of the 'no' votes came from a Trump appointee and loyalist, Stephen Miran, who advocated a rate cut of a quarter percentage, rather than keep them unchanged. This was expected, and he has consistently done this in the past. The other three are the regional Federal Reserve Bank presidents, four of whom are appointed by rotation among 11 such presidents. Hence, these names change regularly.

Thus, one can assume that these regional presidents may continue to favour Powell, and take the number of dissenters against a new Trump-appointed Chair to four, resulting in similar 8:4 splits in the future. That is, until the regional members are replaced by new ones, whose attitudes we are not aware of. In effect, it will not make a difference as the majority decisions will prevail. Things will get ugly and more divided if there is a change of mind among the seven governors, which includes the chair, and which, in the future, will include Powell.

Now, things get interesting if one takes into account the reason for the dissent this time. The three regional presidents said that while they agreed with the hold on interest rate, they "did not support the inclusion of an easing bias in the (official) statement this time." For the trio, the offending line reads, "In considering the extent and timing of additional adjustments to

the target range for the federal funds rate, the Committee (of 12) will carefully assess incoming data, the evolving outlook, and the balance of risks." Everything was fine with it except for the inclusion of a troublesome word, "additional." As the trio explains, the word seems to imply that the intent of the Fed is to cut the rate. Indeed, in technical jargon, it is, and has been, on, what is called, an 'easing bias,' which implies looking for signs to ease or lower the rate, since the latter part of 2025. Instead, the three regional members are worried about the dangers of a persistent inflation, which has not come down, and which, in effect, asks for a higher, not lower, rate. Thus, they do not want to reduce the rate, especially now.

Such notions fly in the face of what Trump wants, and has wished for since he took over for the second time. The noises made by the three dissenters may look like a disagreement with the majority, which includes Trump's baiter, Powell, but it is in effect a signal to the president that they are not happy with even an intent to reduce the interest rate. At this stage, there is no point in even talking about a cut. So, when the new chair decides to cut rates the next time, some of the members may oppose him, and their number may well be more than four.

Over the past year or so, inflation stayed above the Fed's benchmark of two per cent, thanks to Trump's tariffs, which were deemed illegal by the Supreme Court, and soaring energy prices. Most Fed officials feel that these are not temporary due to the duration of the price surges, and are concerned about the long-term impact on the consumers. If inflation stays high, now fueled by the Iran war, a rate cut may be worse, especially if it does not propel growth in the future. Most central bankers are fixated by inflation rather than growth.

However, there is positive news from the "low-hire, low-fire" jobs market. According to a media report, "Nonfarm payrolls in March (2026) grew by a better-than-expected 178,000, while the unemployment rate slipped to 4.3 per cent. For April, payroll processing firm ADP has reported average weekly private payroll growth of around 40,000, further indicating that the jobs picture is healthy if less than robust." If the jobs market seems intact, if not improving dramatically, there may be a case to cut interest rates to boost growth, investments and, therefore, employment.

In effect, the tussle within the Fed Board, and among the policy-makers, and experts, including Trump and his loyalists, is about focus and perceptions. Trump wants to show growth and investments, and most possibly before the midterm elections due this November. Powell is cautious and conservative, and wants to wait-and-watch rather than anticipate things. At present, the Fed Board is with Powell, and he has carried them over three full and part presidencies. However, one cannot be sure of the changing loyalties once Powell is out, and still in.

An illustration featuring a close-up of a silver calculator with a digital display showing the word 'FED' in large, blocky letters. Behind the calculator is a US \$100 bill, showing the portrait of Benjamin Franklin. The image is set against a dark background with some faint, glowing lines.

Left-Handed Economist

Beat category shifts with prices

It is an unusual pricing strategy to boost margins and profits

An abstract illustration showing wisps of white smoke or steam rising from a dark, textured surface. The smoke forms intricate, swirling patterns against a dark background.

on volumes... companies have historically displayed strong pricing power, allowing them to protect profitability even in elevated tax regimes," says one of them. Others contend that given the addictive nature of the products, consumption dips marginally for some time, and may reach new peaks later. Over the decades, despite ups and down, sales have faltered but perked up because of various factors that countered the higher prices.

So, how will the higher prices work in practice? When the prices were hiked across the board, they were forced due to the higher taxes, which implied a 22-28 per cent increase according to the analysts. Hence, one assumes that the difference between the earlier and new prices were entirely because of the tax burden. Thus,

none of the increases helped the bottom line because the extra money did not accrue to the firms. A large proportion of the second price hikes will directly add to the corporate coffers and, thereby, boost both the margins and profits, but only if overall sales and volumes remain intact.

Let us first understand the tax structure. There is a portion that is fixed as a percentage of the invoice prices, another which is fixed as an absolute number, and both depend on the length of the products. In the case of the first price increases, it was because of the two tax components. In the second instance, as invoice prices go up, the percentage tax will go up too, but the fixed component will remain the same. Hence, there will be differences that will remain, and these will end up on the

balance sheets of the manufacturers. Suppose the price was ₹100 in January 2026. In February, because of the new taxes, it went up to ₹150, based on the highest increase in prices. The ₹50 included the percentage tax, and fixed one.

Now, if the firm hikes the price further to, say ₹170, ₹10 may go towards the percentage-based tax, but the remaining ₹10 will accrue to the firm, as the fixed-tax portion remains as it was earlier. Suddenly, the firm is richer by ₹10 per pack of the product. If the overall volumes remain the same, and even if there are switchovers between the price categories, from premium to semi-premium, the higher profits remain intact if the second price hikes too are across the board. Over time, the firm assumes that some of those who switched will revert because of either habit, taste, health or sheer addiction. Ergo, profits will be higher.

This may explain why the share of the leader, the near-monopolist, shot up from ₹304 to more than ₹316 in a single day on Wednesday. Yesterday, it was down by a tad, a mere rupee. The price of the runners-up in the market share zoomed from ₹2,122 to a high of ₹2,284 on Wednesday, before settling down a bit. Yesterday, after dipping to ₹2,218.5, the price was up above ₹2,250, although almost a percentage down compared to the closing the day before. The enthusiasm immediately after the news of second price hikes was slightly dented because the concerns related to further switchovers to low-priced products, and deeper-than-expected dent in volumes.

One will need to watch how the consumers react to the new price hikes, if they happen, and will this contrast with what happened in February and March 2026. As we mentioned earlier, shifts and switch-overs to lower-priced products will matter less, if the price increases are across the board, or even confined to the largest-selling brands. But the overall volumes need to be intact, and even perk up in the future. But if sales shrink, and shifts happen simultaneously, the firms may be in trouble. This may turn out to be the acid test to determine how resilient an addictive and habitual product is, and how far firms can stretch prices.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

India–New Zealand free trade agreement : Steps towards a developed nation with self-confidence



ASHWANI MAHAJAN

The India – New Zealand Free Trade Agreement has been signed, on April 27, 2026, encompassing goods, services, investment, mobility, and regulatory cooperation. This agreement is not merely concerned with the conventional act of reduction in tariffs; rather, it also incorporates Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs), innovation and standards.

It is noteworthy that, currently, various types of trade agreements are observed across the globe. One such category is of multilateral agreements. Based on the 'GATT' agreement, the World Trade Organisation (WTO) came into existence in 1995; this was a multilateral trade agreement that, at that time, included 123 member nations. Subsequently, additional countries joined the pact, thereby becoming part of the World Trade Organisation. Today, the World Trade Organisation has 166 members.

Furthermore, regional trade agreements are frequently concluded, involving multiple nations within a specific geographical region. Examples of such free trade agreements include the North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA), the 'ASEAN' Free Trade Area (comprising nations in Southeast Asia), the European Union (EU), the Southern African Customs Union etc.

Customs Unions are, also a type of regional agreement in which member countries eliminate tariffs (duties) among themselves and apply a uniform tariff on goods imported from outside the bloc. The Regional Comprehensive

Economic Partnership (RCEP) is an example of a major regional trade agreement; it comprises the ten ASEAN nations, along with China, Japan, South Korea, Australia, and New Zealand.

The Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP) is another example of a regional trade agreement. Frequently, individual countries also enter into trade agreements with regional trade blocs. There are numerous global examples of this; for instance, the The India – European Union (EU) Free Trade Agreement (FTA) falls into this category.

Furthermore, we often observe large-scale regional trade agreements involving multiple countries from diverse geographical regions.

Additionally, many trade agreements are bilateral – that is, concluded between two specific countries. The India – New Zealand Free Trade Agreement is one such example. India has previously entered into similar bilateral agreements with various nations; notable examples include the India–United Kingdom Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), the Australia-India Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement (ECTA), the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement of India and Japan (CEPA), and now, the India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement.

It is noteworthy that in recent times – due to actions by the United States such as arbitrarily raising tariffs in violation of World Trade Organisation (WTO) rules, withholding its financial contributions to the organisation, and contributing to deadlocks at ministerial conferences – countries across the globe are becoming increasingly disillusioned with the WTO. All major nations are realising the necessity of re-evaluating global trade agreements.



Consequently, the appeal of bilateral trade agreements among nations is steadily on the rise. Moreover, bilateral agreements are currently being pursued with greater frequency than regional agreements. In 2019, just as India was poised to join the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP), it became apparent that participating in this agreement could inflict severe damage upon the country's agriculture, dairy, and industrial sectors. In light of this, Prime Minister Narendra Modi took a firm decision to opt out of the RCEP. It is noteworthy that the negotiations for this agreement involved 16 countries, including the ten ASEAN nations, Australia, New Zealand, Japan, South Korea, China, and India.

With the sole exception of China, India already has bilateral agreements in place with all the countries participating in the RCEP. Significantly, due to China's adoption of unfair practices, India does not wish to enter into any

form of trade agreement with the country. All of India's exports to New Zealand will receive a 100 per cent exemption from import duties; this will particularly benefit goods such as textiles and apparel, leather products and footwear, pharmaceuticals, and engineering goods. In return, India has granted import duty exemptions to 95 per cent of New Zealand's exports, with 30 per cent of these items receiving immediate exemption. Import duties on the remaining items will be reduced gradually.

Consistent with India's approach in several previous agreements – where certain sensitive sectors were excluded from free trade pacts – sectors such as dairy, sugar, edible oils, spices, and rubber have been excluded from this agreement as well, in order to protect domestic farmers and producers. It is anticipated that this agreement will facilitate market access in New Zealand for 118 categories of services provided

by India, including IT and digital services, financial and professional services, as well as tourism and education services. Furthermore, New Zealand has committed to investing \$20 billion in India over the coming years – investments likely to be directed toward infrastructure, technology, manufacturing, and agricultural value chains.

The agreement also addresses mobility and visa facilitation, offering easier visa access to skilled professionals, students, and practitioners of Yoga and AYUSH (traditional Indian medicine systems) from India. Provisions such as work visas, a Working Holiday Scheme, and post-study work rights have been incorporated into the agreement. While New Zealand's agricultural products – such as apples, kiwis, meat, and seafood – will be permitted for export to India, their entry will be subject to specific import quotas.

As import duties are phased out, careful consideration will be given to ensuring that the agreement does not cause any detriment to India's farmers or the dairy sector. Following this agreement, the objective is to boost the total bilateral trade between India and New Zealand – currently standing at \$1.3 billion – to \$20 billion within a few years. Notably, India's foreign trade has historically been confined to a limited number of traditional partners; this agreement, therefore, presents an opportunity to significantly expand the scope of India's global trade footprint. Concurrently, non-tariff barriers to trade will be eliminated through improvements in standards, customs procedures, and transparency in business operations.

Bilateral agreements concluded with most of India's trading partners demonstrate that India is actively striving to promote free trade by engaging effectively in negotiations with its counterparts. Moving beyond the traditional

framework of free trade agreements, India is now seeking to incorporate provisions regarding investment, mobility, and economic cooperation into these pacts. This also signals that India is not merely forging agreements with developing nations; it is now engaging in more assertive negotiations – on an equal footing – even with developed economies.

The India – New Zealand Free Trade Agreement is one such example. India has previously entered into similar bilateral agreements with various nations; notable examples include the India – United Kingdom Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), the India-Australia Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement (ECTA), the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement of India and Japan (CEPA), and now, the India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement, serve as recent examples of this trend.

We observe that the proposed India-US FTA remains in limbo, indicating that India is in no haste to accept terms that do not align with its best interests. Following the US Supreme Court's decision to overturn tariffs imposed by the Trump administration, India has also slowed the pace of its negotiations with the US; given these recent developments, we may potentially secure further concessions.

The trade agreement with New Zealand once again affirms that India is resolutely moving forward to conclude trade pacts even with developed nations, all while safeguarding its own interests. This reinforces the vision of a 'Developed India' and, through this agreement, fosters the expansion of supply chains and drives export-led growth.

The author is a National Co-convenor, Swadeshi Jagran Manch Former Professor, PGDAV College, University of Delhi

Global trade witnessing moment of quiet but consequential churn: Tharoor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Against a backdrop of rising geopolitical tensions, regulatory divergence, and deepening uncertainty in global trade, leading policymakers and experts called for urgent, coordinated efforts to revitalise the World Trade Organisation (WTO) at a high-level dialogue in New Delhi.

The roundtable, titled "MC14 Outcomes and the Future of the Multilateral Trading System", was jointly organised by the Chintan Research Foundation (CRF) and CUTS International at the India International Centre.

Chairing the session, Shashi Tharoor emphasised that the current challenges facing the WTO go beyond routine negotiating deadlocks and reflect deeper structural shifts in the global trading system. He highlighted growing

geopolitical fragmentation, declining trust among nations, and the shift from universal consensus to more flexible, plurilateral approaches. He stressed that while MC14 may not have delivered major outcomes, it should not be viewed as a failure, but as a reflection of a transforming multilateral order.

Opening the discussion, Pradeep S Mehta, Founder Secretary General, CUTS International, described MC14 as a moment of "disappointment without disruption." While no major breakdown occurred, he noted that the absence of clear outcomes has intensified questions about the WTO's relevance. He highlighted that the system has historically enabled stability, job creation, and development, particularly for developing countries, and must now adapt through more flexible



approaches such as variable geometry. Delivering the keynote address, former WTO Director-General Pascal Lamy pointed to a fundamental shift in global trade dynamics, from protectionism to what he termed "precautionism."

He highlighted that rising regulatory divergence across countries is increasingly shaping trade flows and noted that many of today's

challenges lie beyond the WTO's traditional mandate. He called for reform of both the WTO's rulebook and its governance structures to keep pace with these evolving realities.

Adding a policy perspective, Montek Singh Ahluwalia emphasised the need for pragmatic and realistic approaches to trade policy. He noted that the WTO cannot be expected to resolve macroeconomic

imbalances and stressed the importance of maintaining guardrails while aligning trade policy with domestic competitiveness and investment strategies.

Shishir Priyadarshi, President of CRF, underlined that while the WTO remains indispensable, particularly for developing countries, its credibility has eroded over time. He pointed to the paralysis of the dispute settlement mechanism as a major concern and warned that, without enforceability, global trade risks would be shaped by power rather than rules. He also highlighted the need to balance flexibility with coherence, cautioning against fragmentation arising from unchecked plurilateral approaches.

Speakers noted that the global trading environment is becoming increasingly complex, marked by regulatory divergence, strategic

competition, and shifting economic priorities. The discussion underscored that the current moment reflects not just a temporary impasse, but a broader transformation in the global trade architecture.

At the same time, participants reaffirmed that the WTO remains indispensable by providing a rules-based framework that ensures predictability and stability in global trade. Flexible arrangements were seen as pragmatic interim solutions, though not substitutes for a cohesive multilateral system.

Concluding the discussion, there was broad agreement that the WTO stands at a crossroads. Participants emphasised that this is less a moment of crisis and more a moment of choice, between drift and reform, and that rebuilding trust will be essential to ensuring the system's continued relevance.

Crude oil futures hit record ₹10,571/barrel; Brent breaches \$126

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Crude oil prices jumped by ₹445 to hit a record ₹10,571 per barrel in futures trade on Thursday, with Brent breaching \$126 a barrel in global markets amid reports that US President Donald Trump is weighing military options against Iran.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, crude oil for May delivery jumped by ₹445, or 4.39 per cent, to touch a fresh high of ₹10,571 per barrel, extending gains for the fourth straight session.

Analysts said the rise in oil prices came on the back of reports of a possible military briefing for President Trump on options for action against Iran, raising concerns about further escalation in West Asia.

The briefing signals that Trump was considering major combat operations either to break the deadlock in negotiations or deliver a final blow before ending the war, the reports said.

Globally, Brent oil futures for the June contract extended its gains for the ninth consecutive session, rising by \$4.73, or 3.89 per cent, to hit an intra-day high of \$126.41 per barrel – a level last seen



on March 8, 2022. West Texas Intermediate (WTI) for the same contract also appreciated by \$4.05, or 3.79 per cent, to hit an intra-day high of \$110.93 a barrel in New York.

Market experts said the rally was also fuelled by stalled ceasefire negotiations between the US and Iran, and the surprise exit of the United Arab Emirates from the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC).

Earlier, Trump had rejected Tehran's latest proposal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, indicating the naval blockade would stay in place until a nuclear agreement is reached.

Brokerage firm Kotak Securities, in a note, said escalating US pressure on Iran, including potential extension of a naval blockade and stricter enforcement actions on tanker movements, has heightened concerns over constrained flows through the Strait of Hormuz.

Sensex closes lower by 582 pts as high crude oil prices dent investor sentiment

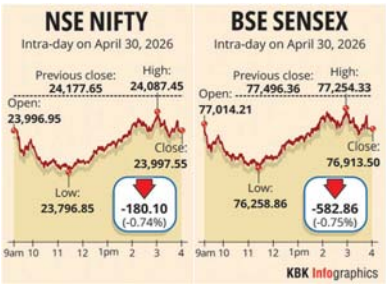
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty closed nearly 1 per cent lower on Thursday as crude oil prices, weak global trends and foreign fund outflows weighed on investor sentiment.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tumbled 582.86 points or 0.75 per cent to settle at 76,913.50. During the day, it plunged 1,237.5 points, or 1.59 per cent, to 76,258.86, but recovered some of the losses in the second half of the session.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dived 180.10 points or 0.74 per cent to end at 23,997.55.

Among the 30-Sensex firms, Eternal, Hindustan Unilever, Tata Steel, Larsen & Toubro, UltraTech Cement and



Mahindra & Mahindra were the major laggards. Sun Pharma, Infosys, Bajaj Finance and Adani Ports were among the gainers. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, traded 1.52 per cent lower at \$116.2 per barrel.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth ₹2,468.42

crisis situation," said Aparna S Sharma at the inter-ministerial briefing on developments in West Asia.

India produced 16.49 lakh tonnes of urea in March and 21 lakh tonnes in April, taking the total to 37.49 lakh tonnes. "It was almost the same during the same period last year, and we have reached that level," Sharma said.

The urea shortfall is being met through imports.

"We floated a global tender and secured about 37 lakh tonnes of urea to meet the shortfall," she added. Domestic production of Di-Ammonium Phosphate (DAP) reached 4.79 lakh tonnes, NPK at 12.69 lakh tonnes and Single Super



Phosphate (SSP) at 7.40 lakh tonnes during the March-April period. A global tender for phosphatic fertilisers has also been floated for 19 lakh

tonnes, and the availability of fertiliser raw materials is being regularly reviewed at all levels.

"Fertiliser availability remains

Government reviews households with dual LPG, PNG connections



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government is identifying households with both liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) and piped natural gas (PNG) connections as it enforces an order prohibiting dual ownership, aiming to curb misuse and better target subsidies.

The Government had last month barred households with piped cooking gas (called PNG) connections from retaining or obtaining subsidised domestic LPG connections. In a notification issued on March 14, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas amended the Liquefied Petroleum Gas (Regulation of Supply and Distribution) Order, 2000, under the Essential Commodities Act, making it mandatory for consumers with PNG connections to surrender their domestic LPG connections.

This was done with a view to accelerating PNG rollout to ease pressure on cooking gas supplies amid global energy supply disruptions.

The amended order also prohibits Government oil companies and their dis-

tributors from providing domestic LPG connections or refilling cylinders for consumers who already have a PNG supply. "Assessment is being done as to how many have dual connections," said Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, at an inter-ministerial press briefing on developments in West Asia. So far, more than 43,000 LPG users, also having PNG connections, have surrendered their LPG connections, she said. This "is a low number. We expect it to be more".

The Government last month issued an order which said, "No person having a piped natural gas (PNG) connection and also having a domestic LPG connection shall retain a domestic LPG connection, or take refills of domestic LPG cylinders from any Government oil company, or through their distributors. Such persons will be required to immediately surrender their domestic LPG connection".

Those having PNG connections have also been barred from obtaining a domestic LPG connection.

robust as ever and supplies continue to exceed requirement," Sharma said.

For Kharif 2026, against a requirement of 390.45 lakh tonnes, current stocks stand at 193.38 lakh tonnes – approximately 50 per cent of the total requirement. Urea availability is at 73.81 lakh tonnes, DAP at 23.47 lakh tonnes, with other fertilisers also well-stocked.

"This reflects improved planning, advanced stocking and efficient logistics managed by the Government. The supply position continues to be strong in the states," Sharma said, adding that there has been no change in the maximum retail price (MRP) of fertilisers.

FROM THE WORLD

SINGAPORE

Three activists fined for protest

An Indian-origin woman was among three Singaporean activists, fined \$2,341 each on Thursday for organising a procession outside the Presidential Palace to show solidarity with Palestine, local media reported. The High Court overturned the acquittal of the three women, Malay-origin Mossamman Sobikun Nahar, 26, Siti Amirah Mohamed Asrori, 30, and Indian-origin Annamalai Kokila Parvathi, 37, accused of organising the procession on February 2, 2024, The Straits Times reported.

CANADA

Child abductor faces deportation

An Indian-origin man, sentenced to 18 months in prison for abducting a child in Canada, faces possible deportation back to his home country . Manoj Govindbalunikam was sentenced earlier this month for abducting a child in Thessalon in 2023. Justice Michael Varpio gave the decision on April 21 at the Sault Courthouse. Govindbalunikam pleaded guilty to the charges, as his lawyer demanded a conditional discharge to help him avoid deportation to India.

Trump floats a new plan to reopen the Strait of Hormuz

ASSOCIATED PRESS/ PTI
■ Washington/Islamabad

Trump floated a new plan to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, a senior official said.

Under the plan, the United States would continue its blockade on Iranian ports, while coordinating with allies to impose higher costs on Iran's attempts to subvert the free flow of energy, according to a senior administration official.

Trump is weighing multiple diplomatic and policy options to push Iran to end its chokehold on the waterway, said the official, who spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to comment publicly.



President Donald Trump speaking to reporters in the Oval Office of the White House

President Donald Trump said Russian President Vladimir Putin, during a phone call Wednesday, renewed his offer for Russia to serve as a third country that could deal

with Iran's 970 pounds of enriched uranium that the US leader is demanding Tehran must surrender.

"He told me he'd like to be involved with the enrich-

ment - if he can help us get it," Trump said Putin told him. "I said, I'd much rather have you be involved with ending the war with Ukraine." To me, that would

be more important." Meanwhile, the Kremlin warned of dire consequences' if hostilities against Iran resume.

Russian President Vladimir Putin discussed the Iran war in a phone call with Trump on Wednesday, with the Kremlin stressing the "dire consequences" if hostilities resumed. Speaking to journalists, presidential adviser Yuri Ushakov said that Putin had told the US president that a ground operation on Iranian territory would be completely "unacceptable and dangerous."

Pak actively mediating US-Iran peace talks

Pakistan on Thursday said that it was actively engaged

with the US and Iran to end the war in West Asia and restore peace and stability in the region and beyond.

"Anything that passes through the conduit of diplomatic channels in Pakistan is honestly communicated to the other side," Foreign Office Spokesperson Tahir Andrabi said at the weekly briefing.

He added that the clock on diplomacy has not stopped but is functional.

"We are in contact with the relevant parties on the matter. Regarding negotiations, both new and old proposals are on the table. We hope peace will prevail," Andrabi said, referring to efforts to bring about an end to hostilities between

the two countries. Andrabi said that Pakistan was hopeful of a negotiated settlement of this issue, emphasising that "we encourage direct negotiations between the two sides". He expressed hope for "stable relations between Iran and the US". The statement came after the second round of talks between the US and Iran could not materialise despite Pakistan's hectic efforts to bring the two sides to the negotiating table.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi made two brief visits to Pakistan within 48 hours over the weekend, meeting with Field Marshal Asim Munir and PM Shehbaz Sharif to discuss the regional situation.

Man accused in Trump attack heads back to court

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

A man accused of trying to storm the White House Correspondents' Association dinner with guns and knives and attempting to kill President Donald Trump agreed on Thursday to remain jailed for now while he awaits trial.

Cole Thomas Allen did not enter a plea during his brief appearance before US Magistrate Moxila Upadhyaya. Prosecutors allege Allen planned his attack for weeks and tracked Trump's movements online before he ran through a magnetometer at the Washington Hilton on Saturday night while holding a long gun and disrupted one of the highest-profile



annual events in the nation's capital. Allen was injured during the attack but was not shot. A Secret Service officer was shot but was wearing a bullet-resistant vest and survived, officials say.

Prosecutors have said they believe Allen fired his shotgun at least once and that a Secret Service agent fired five shots. They have not publicly confirmed that it was Allen's bullet that struck the agent's

vest. In a letter to prosecutors on Wednesday, Allen's lawyers alleged that some of acting Attorney General Todd Blanche's statements "indicate that the recovered ballistics evidence is inconsistent with aspects of the government's theory, evidence collected by the government and/or statements made by witnesses".

The Justice Department, in response, said the evidence shows Allen fired his shotgun at least once in the Secret Service agent's direction. Investigators recovered at least one fragment at the crime scene that is consistent with a buckshot pellet, prosecutors wrote. "The government is aware of no physical evidence, digital video evi-

dence, or witness statements that are inconsistent with the theory that your client fired his shotgun in the direction" of the officer or that the officer "was indeed shot once in the chest while wearing a ballistic vest," prosecutors wrote.

Prosecutors said in court papers that Allen took a picture of himself in his hotel room just minutes before the incident, and that he was outfitted with an ammunition bag, a shoulder gun holster and a sheathed knife.

In a message that authorities say sheds light on his motive, Allen referred to himself as a "Friendly Federal Assassin" and alluded obliquely to grievances over a range of Trump administration action.

PIETRO DE CRISTOFARO
■ Munster

President Donald Trump has again threatened that the United States could reduce its military presence in Germany, a key NATO ally and the European Union's largest economy. Europeans have heard this before.

Trump's social media post followed comments by Chancellor Friedrich Merz that the US was being "humiliated" by Tehran as it slow-walks its diplomacy over the US-Israel war against Iran.

Trump has mused for years about reducing America's military presence in Germany, and has recently repeatedly railed against NATO for its refusal to



assist the US in its two-month — old war. US allies at NATO have been waiting for the Trump administration to pull troops out since just after it came to office, warning that Europe would have to look after its own security, and that of Ukraine, in future. Depending on

operations, exercises and troop rotations, around 80,000-100,000 US personnel are usually stationed in Europe.

NATO allies have expected that US troops deployed after Russia launched its war on Ukraine in 2022 would be first to leave.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Nazia Parveen, D/o Mohd Nadeem, R/o F-11/16, Jogabai Extension, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, hereby declare that my father's name has been mentioned incorrectly in my 10th and 12th class marksheets as "Mohammad Nadeem" instead of the correct name Mohd Nadeem.

PD(998)C
I, Angandeep Singh S/o Rajender Singh R/o A-29A DDA Flats Guru Gobind Singh Kunj Tagore Garden Delhi-110027 have changed my name to Angaddeep Singh.

PD(999)C
I, Rajinder Singh S/o Milap Singh R/o A-29A DDA Flats Guru Gobind Singh Kunj Tagore Garden Delhi-110027 have changed my name to Rajender Singh.

PD(1000)C
I, Swatika Malhotra D/O late Sh. Rajender Malhotra R/o 227/228 (Double Storey) New Rajinder Nagar, Delhi-110060 in death certificate name of my father recorded as Rajender Malhotra and in miscellaneous documents recorded as Raj Malhotra and Rajinder Malhotra all name of my father are one and same person. Correct Name is Rajender Malhotra.

PD(1001)C
I, MADHU MANJARI TIDU W/o GEORGE CELESTINE R/o H. NO. D-73, SECTOR-55, Noida, Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P.-201301 declare MADHU MANJARI TIDU AND MADHU MANJARI are the same person and I am known as MADHU MANJARI TIDU all future purpose.

PD(1002)C

OFFICE OF THE MUNICIPAL CORPORATION, BHOPAL (M.P.)

GARDEN SECTION
SECTION I
Notice Inviting e-Tenders

N.I.T. NO.160/GS/BMC/2026
Online percentage / item rate bids for the following works are invited from registered contractors and firms of reputed fulfilling registration criteria:

1	2026_UAD_504271.1	Plantation work at Adhampur khanti (20000 plants) with 3 year maintenance.	1,60,88,092/-	80,440/-	12,500/-	42 Months
2	2026_UAD_504334.1	Plantation work at Airport plantation site (10000 plants) and Bairaghar bus depo (5000 plants) with 3 year maintenance.	1,18,07,200/-	59,036/-	12,500/-	42 Months
3	2026_UAD_504387.1	Plantation work at Judicial Academy (5000 Plants) and State Dairy farm (10000 Plants) and Kallasote dam nehru nagar (5000 plants) including 3 years Maintenance.	1,58,94,166/-	79,471/-	12,500/-	42 Months

Executive Engineer
Municipal Corporation Bhopal
District Bhopal

T.N. 143/026/027

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Swati Verma (Gurgaon), have lost my original B. Tech Degree Certificate (Enrollment No. 3019713114). A complain was lodged on 17.04.2026, along with Lost Report No. 132270852600670 dated 02.04.2026.
Finder please contact:9811774159.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the general public that Ms. Meena Vazirani D/o. Late Kishan Chand Vazirani R/o. Flat No.57, Block A-2, Prateek Apts., Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110063, claims to be the sole surviving legal heir of Late Asha Vazirani, D/o. Late K.C Vazirani, who expired on 24.12.2012. Late Ms. Asha Vazirani died unmarried and issueless. During her lifetime, she was the absolute owner and in possession of the immovable property bearing description as, DDA built freehold UG Flat bearing No.57, on First Floor, situated at Block A-2 (familiar as Prateek Apartments), Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110063. That Late Ms. Asha Vazirani has been surviving legal heir of Late Asha Vazirani, D/o. Late K.C Vazirani, who expired on 24.12.2012. Late Ms. Asha Vazirani died unmarried and issueless. 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‘India-UK tech pact to secure supply chains’

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

The India-UK Technology Security Initiative (TSI) is a strategic investment in the future that will secure supply chains, the UK Parliament was told during a review of the pact's impact.

TSI, agreed between Prime Ministers Narendra Modi and Keir Starmer in July 2024 and renewed as part of the India-UK Vision 2035, is aimed at strengthening bilateral cooperation in critical and emerging technologies. During a Westminster Hall debate in the House of Commons on Tuesday, UK Minister for AI and Online Safety Kanishka Narayan highlighted UK National Security Adviser (NSA)



Jonathan Powell's recent visit to Delhi for talks with his Indian counterpart, Ajit Doval, to agree that the next phase of the pact. "The TSI is a strategic investment in our future. We are committed to its delivery," said Narayan. "The Technology Security Initiative

is already delivering in biotechnology and health technology, sectors that matter both for our economic growth and for our resilience... It will secure supply chains," he said. The British Indian minister in the Department for Science, Innovation and Technology

(DSIT), who was born in Bihar, stressed that technology and innovation was firmly at the core of the UK's partnership with India.

"The UK and India are natural tech partners, with major Indian tech companies like Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services and Wipro already expanding in the UK, supporting jobs, productivity and innovation across our economy. Dozens of Indian firms and entrepreneurs are investing here in Britain, creating the jobs and growth of the future," he said. "That is why the UK-India Technology Security Initiative exists. It is a landmark partnership, bringing into sharper focus collaboration in frontier technology across telecoms, critical min-

erals, semiconductors, AI, quantum, biotechnology, healthtech and advanced materials.

"It is clear that working closely with India allows us not only to open new opportunities for our businesses and make sure that our technologies rely on secure and trustworthy foundations, but to work with a partner that is increasingly setting the global agenda," he told cross-party MPs. Narayan informed Parliament that the TSI has already delivered several joint innovation projects through the UK-India Joint Centre for AI, which also enables the safe adoption of AI across other TSI sectors.

The India-UK Connectivity and Innovation Centre, with

an initial 24 million pounds in joint funding, is driving innovation in how AI is used in telecoms networks and non-terrestrial networks such as satellite internet and telecoms cybersecurity.

Meanwhile, a letter of intent between the UK's National Institute for Health and Care Research and India's Department of Biotechnology will drive innovation in femtech – improving health outcomes for women. The minister from Wales added: "Through the UK-India Critical Minerals Guild, we are strengthening joint capabilities in critical minerals; I will closely consider its collective feedback and its particular observations on the partnership on critical minerals. (PTT)

Nepal's forest ministry signs WWF deal for biodiversity conservation



SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

Nepal's Ministry of Forests and Environment and World Wildlife Fund (WWF) have inked an agreement to strengthen collaboration on biodiversity conservation and sustainable development across the Himalayan nation.

The agreement, relating to a Scope of Cooperation (SoC), aligns joint efforts with the country's national priorities and global commitments, including key policies and strategies on biodiversity, forests and sustainable development, as well as the Sustainable Development Goals and national planning frameworks, according to a press statement issued by WWF Nepal. "These policy frameworks collectively stress

the conservation of biological resources as a foundation for Nepal's sustainable development. The SoC further recognises the importance of landscape-level strategies and species conservation action plans in guiding effective, on-the-ground implementation," it said. WWF said that its collaboration with Nepal reflects a shared commitment to protect the Himalayan nation's rich biodiversity. "Through this Scope of Cooperation, we aim to scale impactful, science-based and community-driven solutions across conservation landscapes, contributing to Nepal's national priorities and global environmental commitments," remarked Ghana Shyam Gurung, Country Representative, WWF Nepal. (PTI)

Media groups call on Israel to allow foreign reporters access to Gaza



DEEPTI HAJELA ■ Washington

The leaders of major media companies around the world are calling on Israel's Government to lift a ban keeping foreign journalists from being able to independently enter and report from Gaza, a barrier that's been in place since the war's start in 2023 and continues even as a ceasefire has been in place for more than six months.

"Being on the ground is essential. It allows journalists to question official accounts on all sides, to speak directly with civilians and report back what they witness firsthand," said the statement from the executives, released on Thursday. "That is why news organisations send their reporters into the field, often at great personal risk."

The top editors of more than two dozen organisations said the Israeli has so far not responded to their efforts to discuss the situation. They questioned the country's rationales for why the restrictions are still in place. (AP)

Israel intercepts Gaza aid flotilla near Crete, say activists

ELENA BECATOROS ■ Athens

Activists sailing on dozens of boats attempting to break Israel's maritime blockade of the Gaza Strip to deliver humanitarian aid say Israeli forces intercepted them on Thursday, detaining the crews while the flotilla was sailing near the southern Greek island of Crete.

The Global Sumud Flotilla set sail earlier this month from Barcelona. Organisers have said more than 70 boats and 1,000 people from around the world would be participating, with more vessels joining the original boats as the flotilla sailed east across the Mediterranean. Their attempt comes less



than a year after Israeli authorities foiled another effort by the activist group to reach Gaza. "Israel's actions mark a dangerous and unprecedented escalation, the abduction of civilians in

the middle of the Mediterranean, over 600 miles from Gaza, in full view of the world," the group said. Israel's Foreign Ministry said in a post on X that it was taking about 175 activists

from more than 20 boats participating in the flotilla to Israel. Israel and Egypt have imposed varying degrees of a blockade on Gaza since Hamas seized power from rival Palestinian forces in 2007. Israel says the blockade is needed to prevent Hamas from importing arms, while critics say it amounts to collective punishment of Gaza's Palestinian population.

Turkey's foreign ministry condemned the seizure of the flotilla Thursday as "an act of piracy." "By targeting the Global Sumud Flotilla, whose mission is to draw attention to the humanitarian catastrophe faced by the innocent people of Gaza, Israel has also violated

humanitarian principles and international law," the ministry said in a statement.

Turkish foreign ministry spokesman Oncu Keceli wrote on X that Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan had discussed the raid over the phone with his Spanish counterpart Jose Manuel Albares Bueno.

Activists in Greece said they planned a protest rally Thursday afternoon outside the Greek foreign ministry in Athens, saying Israel's interception of the boats occurred within the maritime zone that falls under Greece's responsibility for search and rescue operations and that the country's coast guard had not reacted. (AP)

Sydney attack inquiry urges gun reform

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Melbourne

A Government inquiry into a rise in antisemitism across Australia before a mass shooting killed 15 people at a Hannukah celebration late last year recommended on Thursday that authorities prioritize gun reform.

The Government established the Royal Commission on Antisemitism and Social Cohesion after father and son Sajid and Naveed Akram allegedly opened fire with legally-owned guns at the celebration at Bondi Beach on December 14, 2025. Authorities say their attack



was inspired by the Islamic State group. Royal Commissioner Virginia Bell made 14 recommendations on Thursday in her first interim report, five of which were not made public because they were classified as confidential for national security reasons.

Eight injured in alleged cross-border shelling by Afghan- Taliban in Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Peshawar

Eight civilians, including women and children, were injured in cross-border shelling allegedly carried out by Afghan Taliban forces at a residential border area in Pakistan's northwestern Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Province, police said on Thursday.

The shelling hit the houses in Angoor Adda, a border region of South Waziristan, late Wednesday.

Multiple houses were damaged in the shelling, with a total of eight people injured, including women and children, the Deputy Commissioner of South Waziristan Lower, Shahid Ali Khan, said.

Medical officer Dr Ashfaq confirmed that the injured were shifted to a nearby hospital, where they received initial treatment before being referred to hospitals in Dera Ismail Khan and Peshawar for further



care. Authorities are assessing the full extent of the damage caused by what officials described as unprovoked aggression targeting the civilian population in the border area.

First US-Venezuela commercial flight lands in Caracas

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Caracas

The first direct commercial flight between the United States and Venezuela is scheduled to land in the Venezuelan capital, Caracas, seven years after the US Department of Homeland Security ordered an indefinite suspension, citing security concerns.

The resumption of a commercial flight between the two countries comes in the wake of the US capture of Nicolas Maduro in a stunning nighttime raid on his residence in Caracas, Venezuela's capital, in early January.

It also comes a month after the US formally reopened its embassy in Caracas following the



restoration of full diplomatic relations with the South American country.

Flight AA3599 operated by Envoy Air, a subsidiary of American Airlines, was scheduled to depart from Miami at 10.16 AM local time and arrive three hours later in the Venezuelan Capital, returning to Florida later in the afternoon. Earlier, the airline said a second daily

flight between Miami and Caracas will start on May 21.

In late January, US President Donald Trump said he informed Venezuela's acting President Delcy Rodriguez that he would open up all commercial airspace over Venezuela, allowing Americans to visit.

"American citizens will be very shortly able to go to Venezuela, and they'll be

safe there," Trump said at the time. The flights mark the resumption of nonstop travel between the US and Venezuela for the first time since diplomatic ties were severed in 2019. For the past seven years, passengers have relied on international airlines and indirect routes through neighbouring Latin American countries.

In January, when the airline announced the resumption of flights it said it would give customers the opportunity to reunite with families and pursue new business opportunities.

Airlines was the last US airline flying to Venezuela. It suspended flights in 2019 between Miami and Caracas, as well as flights to the oil hub city of Maracaibo.

NYC mayor Mamdani to ask King Charles to return Koh-i-Noor

YOSHITA SINGH ■ New York

New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani said he would encourage King Charles III to return the Koh-i-Noor diamond. "If I was to speak to the King separately from that, I would probably encourage him to return the Koh-i-Noor diamond," Mamdani said at a press conference before he met the British monarch in the city later in the day.

Mamdani was asked what he would say to the King, who visited New York City on the second day of his State Visit to the US. King Charles addressed a joint meeting of the US Congress Tuesday, as he and



Queen Camilla were honoured at a state dinner hosted by President Donald Trump and First Lady Melania Trump in the White House.

King Charles and Queen Camilla visited the 9/11 Memorial in the city and paid their respects to the victims of the terror attack.

They also visited Harlem Grown, a network of urban farms supporting

children and families in Upper Manhattan.

Mamdani met King Charles at the 9/11 memorial. The 105.6-carat Koh-i-Noor diamond was given to Queen Victoria in 1849 by Maharajah Duleep Singh. It was worn by the Queen Mother on her crown in 1937. India has indicated that it will continue to explore ways to bring back the Koh-i-noor from the United Kingdom.

The country has been raising the matter from time to time with the UK Government and said it will continue to explore ways and means for obtaining a "satisfactory resolution of the matter." (PTT)

NZ court rejects mosque gunman's appeal against guilty pleas



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Wellington

The white supremacist who shot and killed 51 Muslims at two mosques in Christchurch, New Zealand, lost an attempt to undo his guilty pleas in a Court of Appeal ruling.

The panel of three judges dismissed Brenton Tarrant's claim that harsh prison conditions prompted him to make an involuntarily admission to terrorism, murder and attempted murder charges. His bid to withdraw his guilty pleas and seek a trial was "utterly devoid of merit," they wrote.

The Australian man, who is now 35, killed 51 worshippers and injured dozens more in March 2019 when he drove to two Christchurch mosques and opened fire with semiautomatic weapons during Friday prayers.

Tarrant's guilty pleas in March 2020 brought relief to bereaved families and survivors of the attack, who feared he would use a public trial to air his hateful views.

US senators propose a bill to strengthen India, West Asia and Europe trade ties

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

A bipartisan bill has been introduced in the US Senate to strengthen the eastern Mediterranean region's role as a strategic connector between the US, India, the West Asia and Europe.

The Eastern Mediterranean Gateway Act, introduced by US Senators Cory Booker (Democrat) and Dave McCormick (Republican), seeks to mobilise US support for ports, digital corridors, and other strategic infrastructure designed to diversify and secure energy flows, strengthen regional supply chains, and deepen diplomatic ties with key partners.

"Global energy security and supply chains are under growing



strain, and the Eastern Mediterranean is emerging as a critical region for enhancing stability and cooperation on a range of shared strategic interests, including support for the US-India-West Asia-Europe Economic Corridor" Booker said in a statement.

"I am proud to introduce this important bipartisan legislation to strengthen energy security, accelerate innovation and economic growth, and deepen regional partnerships," he said.

The bill would also expand collaboration in innovation, science, and emerging technologies, reinforcing and modernising existing regional frameworks.

By supporting the Eastern Mediterranean as a vital connective hub linking Europe, the West

Asia, and India, the legislation advances core US interests: strengthening energy security, enhancing economic integration, and promoting long-term regional stability.

"The Eastern Mediterranean Gateway Act strengthens these partnerships, makes the region a bigger priority for the US, and helps secure the India-West Asia-Europe Economic Corridor, so critical trade and energy routes aren't left vulnerable to Iran, China, or other adversaries," McCormick said.

The Act seeks to strengthen US backing for the India-West Asia-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC), recognising the region's role as a strategic gateway, and reinforces existing regional initia-

tives, including the 3+1 framework with Greece, Israel, and Cyprus, and the East Mediterranean Gas Forum.

The legislation also seeks to elevate the Eastern Mediterranean as a strategic priority within US foreign policy; establish regular high-level strategic dialogues with IMEC partners and regional allies and advance cross-border energy and infrastructure projects.

It also seeks to assess opportunities to expand successful US-Israel innovation and technology programmes to additional regional partners, and evaluate multilateral models like Cyprus's CYCLOPS centre for regional integration. The India-West Asia-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) was announced at the G20 Leaders' Summit in New Delhi in 2023. (PTT)

PROSPECT

UNSW Bengaluru gets AI centre boost from Deloitte MoU



The University of New South Wales (UNSW) Sydney has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Deloitte India to establish a Centre of Excellence (CoE) in AI and Innovation at its new Bengaluru campus.

This strategic collaboration unites a global top-20 university with India's leading AI and innovation practice. It aims to connect academia, students, and industry to develop future-ready talent for India's fast-evolving economy.

The partnership will create a platform integrating education, industry-relevant practice, applied research, and knowledge exchange. UNSW Bengaluru students will gain direct exposure to real-world problem-solving and insights from India's top AI and innovation practitioners.

The MoU will also enable joint applied research, with UNSW faculty and Deloitte experts tackling industry challenges to produce white papers and innovation-led solutions. A dedicated start-up and innovation lab will support student and faculty entrepreneurship, fostering experimentation, problem-solving, and enterprise.

Professor Sarah Maddison, UNSW Sydney's Deputy Vice-Chancellor (Education & Student Experience), said: "As Australia's number one university for employment outcomes, UNSW's collaboration with Deloitte India will equip students with the confidence, adaptability, and purpose to thrive in a rapidly changing world."

Kamlesh Vyas, Partner at Deloitte India, added, "This partnership with UNSW Sydney marks a defining step in harnessing our tech capabilities to build future-ready talent and drive India's next phase of digital transformation."

Bharat Gaurav Tourist train to launch 07 Jyotirlinga Yatra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

To promote heritage, pilgrimage tourism in India, Bharat Gaurav Tourist train will be operated exclusive circuits "07 Jyotirlinga Yatra" in the month of May. Tours will start from Delhi Safdarjung Railway Station.

From heritage, pilgrimage shores, the "07 Jyotirlinga Yatra" tour has it all.

Spanning over a period of 12 days, this tour will cover a host of places like **Mahakaleshwar Jyotirlinga (Ujjain)** situated in the ancient city of Ujjain on the side of the Kshipra (Shipra) River. It is one of the twelve Jyotirlingas, where Shiva is revered as Mahakaleshwar (Lord of Time and Death).

Omkareshwar Jyotirlinga (Omkareshwar) situated on an island called Mandhata in the Narmada River, which is shaped like the holy symbol "Om" Nageshwar Jyotirlinga temple (Dwarka).

Significance: One of the 12 sacred Jyotirlingas, known for protecting devotees from poison and negativity.

Beyt Dwarka (Island Temple) Significance: Believed to be the original residence of Lord Krishna. It is an island accessible by boat via Okha peninsula, located about 34 km from Dwarka town.



Dwarkadhish Temple Significance: Considered the kingdom of Lord Krishna, dating back 1500 BC.

Somnath Jyotirlinga (Veraval) It is believed that the shrine was built in four stages: Gold (by Moon God/Soma), Silver (by Ravana), Sandalwood (by Lord Krishna), and Stone (by Bhimdeva).

Triyambakeshwar Jyotirlinga (Nashik) Shri Trimbakeshwar is a religious center having one of the twelve Jyotirlinga. The extraordinary feature of the Jyotirlinga located here is its three faces embodying Brahma, Vishnu, and Shiva. Due to the exces-



sive use of water, the linga has started to erode.

Bhimashankar Jyotirlinga (Pune) Lord Shiva manifesting in the Sahyadri hills to destroy the demon Bhima, son of Kumbhakarna.

Grishneshwar Jyotirlinga (Chhatrapati Sambhaji nagar) It features red stone construction, intricate carvings, and a pyramidal shikara in the South Indian style.

07 Jyotirlinga Yatra has been launched at a special price of ₹48500 per person for II AC and ₹ 36560 for III AC and ₹23505 for Sleeper class. Package price is inclusive of train journey in respective AC II, AC III &

Sleeper class, accommodation in AC Budget Hotels and Non AC Budget hotels, all meals (veg only), all transfer and sight-seeing in AC and Non AC vehicles, accidental travel insurance and services of IRCTC Tour Manager etc.

For more details one can visit IRCTC website: <https://www.irctctourism.com/m/bharatgaurav> and book thepackage online, on first come first serve basis.

For more information, one can contact on email: hanuman.singh@irctc.com. Mobile nos. 7827970027, 8595924209, 8287930712 and 8287930686

BRO holds Chief Engineers' Works Conference for eastern region in Guwahati



TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

A two-day Chief Engineers' Works Conference of all Border Roads Organisation (BRO) Projects of the Eastern Region was successfully conducted in Guwahati on April 28 and 29 under the chairmanship of Jitendra Prasad, Additional Director General Border Roads (East).

The conference witnessed the participation of all seven Chief Engineers of BRO Projects in the Eastern Region along with the Commandant, Engineer Base Workshop (EBW).

The primary objective of the conference was to deliberate on the roadmap for the current financial year and to formulate effective strategies for achieving the laid-down targets.

Comprehensive discussions were held on enhancing operational efficiency, optimising resource utilisation and ensuring timely completion of infrastructure

projects. Emphasis was also laid on adopting best practices to improve execution timelines and overall project delivery.

Addressing the gathering, the Addl DGBR (East) stressed the need to accelerate the pace of works while maintaining the highest standards of quality in all ongoing and future projects.

He underscored that quality infrastructure is vital not only for operational effectiveness but also for sustaining public confidence and organisational credibility.

The conference concluded with a clear focus on achieving higher targets and expediting the completion of strategically important road projects. The deliberations are expected to inject renewed momentum into ongoing works and further strengthen the commitment of Border Roads Organisation towards nation-building through robust infrastructure development.

Lieutenant General Vijay B Nair takes over as Commandant, The Infantry School, Mhow

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lieutenant General Vijay B Nair, Ati Vishist Sewa Medal (AVSM), Sena Medal (SM) assumed the appointment of Commandant, The Infantry School, Mhow on May 01. A distinguished alumnus of Sainik School Kazhakootam, National Defence Academy and Indian Military Academy, Lieutenant General Vijay B Nair was commissioned into 21 PUNJAB in June 1988 and later commanded the same battalion.

In his illustrious career spanning thirty-eight years, the General Officer has wide-ranging experience of command, staff & instructional appointments including command of a Brigade under the Desert Strike Corps, Leh Sub Area, Tiger Division in J&K and Vajra Corps in Punjab. Among other operational assignments, his tenure as part of Indian Peace Keeping Forces in Sri Lanka, eight tenures along the Line of Control and



Lieutenant General Vijay B Nair

in Counter Terrorist operations in Jammu and Kashmir were notable, in addition to important staff and prestigious instructional appointments including Chief of Staff Western Command and Northern Command before taking over as Commandant Infantry School.

His international exposures include Indian Military Training Team Bhutan

and Chief of Staff in a multinational Brigade in a United Nations Chapter VII mission.

His meritorious service has been substantiated with the award of Ati Vishist Sewa Medal, Sena Medal and Army Commanders' Commendation Cards (four times), as well as the United Nations Force Commander's Commendation in war-torn Congo.

The erudite General officer is a graduate of the Defence Services Staff College Wellington, College of Defence Management, Secunderabad and National Defence College. His instructional assignments include Senior Command Wing, Army War College, Senior Instructor and Head of Training Team Army in Defence Services Staff College.

The General Officer is married to Mrs Uma Nair and their son, Major Nikhil Nair, following his father's footsteps was commissioned in the same Battalion. His daughter Nikita is presently working for Amazon in Bangalore.

Argentina-India consolidate strategic partnership to advance global edible oil security and agricultural cooperation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Argentine Ambassador to India Mariano Caucino stated that his country and India "have forged a dynamic strategic partnership that extends beyond commerce—grounded in mutual trust, secure edible oil supply, and a shared commitment to advancing global food security, agricultural innovation, and long-term resilience".

The Argentine envoy stated that "at the same time, both governments are deepening their collaboration through expanded technical, scientific, and agricultural cooperation, reinforcing a forward-looking relationship focused on innovation, sustainability, and shared prosperity".

After paying a visit to the Drone Federation of India in New Delhi, Ambassador Caucino affirmed that "we had a very productive meeting with the Drone Federation of India to explore opportunities for the industry to expand in an agricultural powerhouse like Argentina".

Ambassador Caucino was accompanied by Argentine Agriculture Attache Mariano Beheran who explained that "today, tractors from Captain, Mahindra, and other Indian manufacturers are highly valued and increasingly demanded by Argentine farmers. The best-selling sorghum genetic in Argentina comes from an Indian company whose technology was developed in India. There is already a strong and growing symbiosis between the agricultural sectors of both nations."

Following PM Narendra Modi's visit to Argentina in 2025, and as a continuation of the renewed momentum in bilateral relations, Argentina was honoured to subsequently welcome, within the framework of the Joint Working Group (JWG) on Agriculture, a distinguished delegation from India's Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare to the city of Rosario, Argentina (the second largest in the country). This visit reflected a shared spirit of cooperation, technical exchange, and the devel-



opment of a common agenda aimed at strengthening food security, agro-industrial development, and strategic opportunities between both nations. During their visit, the delegation had the opportunity to gain firsthand insight into diverse agricultural production models and tour Latin America's most important vegetable oil cluster, reaffirming Argentina's commitment to open, constructive, and long-term collaboration with India. Beheran stated that "Argentina is currently concluding one of its strongest sunflower harvest seasons in decades, further strengthening its capacity to supply the world with sun-

flower oil from a region far removed from armed conflicts and biodiesel mandates that often constrain export volumes elsewhere".

Soybean oil serves as the safest strategic alternative when palm or sunflower oil face restrictions from other origins, further consolidating the India-Argentina partnership and reinforcing Argentina's position as India's leading supplier of premium-quality edible oils. Argentina's strength lies not only in producing soybeans and sunflower, but also in transforming them industrially through its extensive installed crushing capacity and highly developed logistics network.

DAILY SUDOKU

					1			
	7	9			5		8	
				6			7	4
4		3	1			7		
	7			3		6		8
	2				6	5		
2	3			7				
	9		2			3	1	
		6						

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (30.04.26)								
2	7	3	6	5	8	9	1	4
4	9	8	2	7	1	6	5	3
6	5	1	9	3	4	2	8	7
1	3	2	8	9	5	7	4	6
8	6	5	4	2	7	1	3	9
7	4	9	1	6	3	8	2	5
5	8	4	7	1	6	3	9	2
9	1	7	3	4	2	5	6	8
3	2	6	5	8	9	4	7	1

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
FRIDAY | MAY 01, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6
	8	9			
10					13
		14		15	16
17	18		19		
			21		
			22		
26	27			28	
29					
32				30	
				31	
				33	

- ACROSS**
- 1 An engineer of towering reputation (6)
7 Formally kill the wild boar at the field entrance (8)
8 Not exactly town dress? (4)
10 Became more sociable, needing a new hat to get married (6)
11 The man composed a song (6)
14 Permitted a degree of doubletalk (3)
16 Appetising, being of Rita's type (5)
17 Animal of retrograde breeding? (4)
19 Being whirled, roughly speaking, its goes round (5)
21 Group of fliers bashful about a day of

- DOWN**
- 1 Excited, robbed of a century, departed from the scene (6)
2 Best of the bunch? (6)
3 Real property, money also (4)
4 How the butchers went into business? (7)
5 Brief study? (5)
6 Cracksmen's companion (5)
8 Good beer goes like the wind! (4)
9 For such days, we need a perfect ending (3)
12 Most data is wrong, just a little (3)
13 Study of French? (5)
15 Many finished at the seaside (5)

- 16 Wells (5)
18 Put it by (5)
19 Stepped (5)
21 Salted (5)
22 Fit to go (5)
23 Ledge (5)
25 Score (5)
26 Sale (5)
28 Be-t (5)
29 Enthusiastic about centralisation? (6)
30 Sort of canoe an old soldier may remember (6)
31 Violently separated; but again, not loveless (4)
32 Heading for the nineteenth hole? (2,6)
33 Weaken, having hesitation (6)

- 18 He's said to be in current circulation (5)
19 Being a success, is apt to take a bow (3)
20 Looking embarrassed, having only three of the letters (3)
21 Relief for a civic leader on tour (7)
22 High point of an oratorio (3)
23 Something like a horseshoe (6)
24 A sound eight watchable from the river bank (4)
25 Stagger like an old junk man? (6)
26 Pulsating way to make broth (5)
27 Game involving a striker? (5)
28 Expected a nobleman to lose a kilo (3)
30 Extracted moisture outright! (4)

Lanxess inks MoU with IOCL

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lanxess announced setting up of a new blending plant at its chemical manufacturing site in Jhagadia, Gujarat, with an outlay of ₹150 crore. The facility will manufacture specialty lubricant additives, an official statement said. The company also signed an MoU with Indian Oil Corporation Limited.

"With this plant we are reinforcing our strong commitment to our customers in the region. This facility strengthens our ability to reliably serve customers across India, the Middle East and other markets with high-quality, innovative lubricant additive solutions, using a local-for-local approach," Neelanjana Banerjee, Global Head of the lubricant additives unit of Lanxess said.

E-Tender Notice
GURU NANAK DEV UNIVERSITY, AMRITSAR
SHORT TERM E-TENDER NOTICE
Short Term E-Tenders are invited for the purchase of Desktop Computer & Printer and Melt Spinning Machine be submitted online latest by **15/05/2026 upto 4:00 p.m.** Detailed information can be obtained from website **www.eproc.punjab.gov.in**. Any corrigendum/Addendum related to these e-tender will be uploaded, if required, on Punjab Govt. website:
eproc.punjab.gov.in
Director of Research
2426/12/2026-27/11048
Dated CHD :- 30/04/2026

verka®			
THE PUNJAB STATE COOPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS FEDERATION LTD. SCO 153-155, SECTOR 34-A, CHANDIGARH-160022. EPABX NO. 0172-5041812,66			
Notice Inviting Tender			
www.verka.coop			
e/Sealed Tenders are hereby invited for the purchase and supply of following items:-			
Sr. No.	Name of Work/Item	Period/Tentative Qty	
1.	For Verka Head Office, Chandigarh a) Construction of sewer lines, roads, installation of electrical poles along with allied works etc. within premises of Verka Jalandhar Dairy. b) Construction of Verka Milk Bars of size 10'x10' at various locations throughout Punjab & Chandigarh.	Annual 200 No's/ Annual	
2.	For Verka Bathinda Dairy DSITC of 125 KVA DG sets.	05 No's	
3.	For Verka Jalandhar Dairy Hiring of Pest and Rodent Control Services.	Annual	
4.	For Verka Ludhiana Dairy Supply, installation & commissioning of automatic SMP/WMP powder filling machine in 9/10kg tin with Automatic Nitrogen filling system cap.100 tin per hour.	One job	
5.	For Verka Hoshiarpur Dairy Hiring of Car (Sedan-Honda Amaze, Maruti Swift etc.) is required for Marketing purpose.	01 No.	
6.	For Verka Gurdaspur Dairy Hiring of insulated road milk tankers for transportation of milk from Verka Gurdaspur Dairy to other milk unions (vice-versa) within and outside state.	04 No's (Cap.10 MT-01 15 MT-01 20 MT-02)	
7.	For Verka Ferozepur Dairy Hiring of Mahindra Pick up/ Maxi truck or equivalent to lift can milk from various societies/Dairy farms to MCC/Milk Plant.	Annual/ 07 No's	
8.	For Verka Amritsar Dairy Sealed tender Press notice for outsourcing of Milk Bar at MCC Patti.	01 No.	
7.	For Verka Mega Dairy, Bassi Pathana Nitric Acid (52.0-54.0)	Annual	
9.	For Cattle Feed Plant, Ghanaia ke Bangor Hiring of passenger vehicles (Bolero/Swift Dzire/Toyota Etios or equivalent) for the area of Punjab, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu & Kashmir, Chandigarh and Haryana.	Annual/02 No's	
10.	For Cattle Feed Plant, Bhatiana (Khanna) a) Transportation of Molasses from i. The Batala Cooperative Sugar Mills to CFP, Khanna. ii. The Ajnala Cooperative Sugar Mills to CFP, Khanna. iii. The Budhewal Cooperative Sugar Mills to CFP, Khanna. iv. The Gurdaspur Cooperative Sugar Mills to CFP, Khanna. b) Live Yeast Saccharomyces Cerevisiae c) CU Mintrex d) MN Mintrex e) ZN Mintrex f) Copper Sulphate g) Potassium Iodide h) HMT/Ba/MFP i) Sodium Borate j) Corrigendum/Addendum related to these e-tender will be uploaded, if required, on Punjab Govt. website: eproc.punjab.gov.in Director of Research 2426/12/2026-27/11048 Dated CHD :- 30/04/2026	Khanna Qty in MTs Annual - - - - 19 5.5 12.5 30.06 2.1 0.75 40 2 0.9 175 (3 Months)	GKB Qty in MTs Annual - - - - 30 4 5 12 2 0.1 20 5 0.02 150 (Months)

NOTE:
1. For complete details regarding above tender (NT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. eproc.punjab.gov.in.
2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.

1018/12/2026-27/11086

General Manager (Purchase)

BRIEFLY

Hakimi to miss Champions League semifinal due to injury



Paris Saint-Germain defender Achraf Hakimi will miss the return leg of the Champions League semifinal against Bayern Munich because of a right thigh injury, the French club said. The Morocco right back sustained the injury during PSG's thrilling 5-4 win over Bayern in the first leg on Tuesday. He will be out of action for several weeks.

The second leg of the semifinal is next Wednesday in Munich. It's the second time this season that Hakimi has been injured against Bayern. He missed several weeks after damaging his left ankle during a 2-1 loss to Bayern in the Champions League group stage in November.

Rhodes, Klaasen, Faf buy Rotterdam franchise of ETPL



Former South African cricketers Jonty Rhodes, Faf du Plessis and Heinrich Klaasen have jointly bought a franchise of the European T20 Premier League (ETPL) based in Rotterdam.

The Rotterdam franchise will compete in the inaugural season scheduled from August 26 to September 20. The other city-based franchises are Glasgow, Amsterdam, Edinburgh, Dublin and Belfast. "It's special to join Jonty and Klaasy in acquiring a franchise in the ETPL. This is my first step into team ownership, and the timing couldn't be better with European cricket gaining real momentum," said du Plessis in a statement.

Spirited Indian men fight back to pip Slovakia



Indian men staged a spirited comeback to edge past Slovakia 3-2 in a gripping Group 7 tie at the ITF World Team Table Tennis Championships. With the win, India climbed to the top of the group standings and strengthened their position ahead of their next tie against Guatemala.

The contest ebbed and flowed before India sealed victory through resilience and composure under pressure. Slovakia drew first blood as Lubomir Pistej, ranked 149, used his experience to outmanoeuvre Manush Shah, ranked Number 51, in a five-game opener, handing his side an early lead.

Arteta infuriated by decision to overturn penalty against Atletico Madrid

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Arsenal manager Mikel Arteta called it "unacceptable" and said it was a moment that changed the course of his team's Champions League semifinal against Atletico Madrid.

Meanwhile, Atletico coach Diego Simeone's antics while referee Danny Makkelie studied the sideline monitor at the Metropolitano stadium came under scrutiny Wednesday.

In a white-hot atmosphere and the score locked at 1-1 in Madrid, the Dutch official opted to overturn a second-half penalty awarded to Arsenal when substitute Eberechi Eze went down under a challenge from David Hancko.

"The whole sequence tells the story. I mean it's a clear contact," Arteta told TNT Sports. "At this level it's completely unacceptable."

The game ended 1-1 with the second leg taking place at Arsenal's Emirates Stadium next week.



Arteta said Makkelie had reviewed the penalty incident 13 times before deciding to overturn his decision. Soccer's rules state decisions should not be changed unless there is a "clear and obvious error."

"You make that decision, you cannot overturn that decision when you have to look at it 13 times," Arteta added.

UEFA said the penalty was ruled out because no foul had been committed, despite replays showing clear contact between Hancko and Eze.

Race for Champions League qualification keeping Bundesliga on edge

CIARAN FAHEYAP ■ Berlin

Four teams are vying to join Bayern Munich and Borussia Dortmund in the Champions League next season and a host more are fighting for survival in the Bundesliga.

Last-placed Heidenheim could be relegated this weekend, possibly replaced by second-division leader Schalke, which can seal promotion.



There are no games on Friday as it's May Day, traditionally a day of demonstrations and worker protests accompanied by a heavy police presence across Germany. May Day falls on a Saturday next year, when there will be no matches at all over the whole weekend because of the anticipated security requirements.

Saturday's and Sunday's games are unaffected this year. The Women's Bundesliga is also unaffected, with Union Berlin visiting Hamburger SV on Friday. Bayern sealed the women's title as it did the men's already.

Key matchups: Heidenheim faces a daunting trip to Bayern on Saturday.



Heidenheim boosted its hopes of avoiding the drop with wins over Union Berlin and St Pauli this month. But a win at Bayern would be a major surprise, even if the already crowned league champion is likely to field a B team

before its Champions League semifinal second leg against Paris Saint Germain next week. PSG won a pulsating first leg 5-4 on Tuesday.

Heidenheim would be relegated by a defeat in Munich if St

Arsenal and Atletico exchange penalty goals in 1-1 draw

TALES AZZONIAP ■ Madrid

Atletico Madrid and Arsenal exchanged penalties in a 1-1 draw in the first leg of the Champions League semifinals on Wednesday, a gritty encounter with plenty of intensity from start to finish even if it lacked the fireworks of a nine-goal thriller in Paris.

Defending champion Paris Saint-Germain had edged Bayern Munich 5-4 in France in Tuesday's semifinal. Viktor Gyokeres put Arsenal ahead at the Metropolitano stadium by converting a 44th-minute penalty kick. Julian Alvarez equalised for Atletico — also from the penalty spot — in the 56th.

Arsenal was awarded another penalty in the 78th after Eberechi Eze was brought down by David Hancko inside the area, but the call was overturned — several moments later — after a video review.

The second leg is in London next Tuesday, when



both clubs will try to return to the final after a long absence and earn a chance to win the European title for the first time.

"Here you have to suffer. Many teams have suffered here, including some of the best in the world," Arsenal coach Mikel Arteta said. "We had some good moments in the match and moments

where we had to suffer. The margins are very slim. We are in an incredible position — the semifinal of the Champions League. We have to play in front of our people — it's in our hands."

In the league phase of the competition, Arsenal routed Atletico 4-0 at the Emirates Stadium. Atletico last made it to the Champions League

Zaragoza goalkeeper Andrada handed 12-match suspension



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Zaragoza's Argentine goalkeeper Esteban Andrada was given a 12-match suspension for punching an opponent in a second-division soccer game in Spain this weekend.

Andrada was also suspended for one more match for a red card he was shown before the punch.

The game was in its final minutes when Andrada shoved Huesca defender Jorge Pulido to the ground when he approached the Argentine goalkeeper. After the referee showed Andrada a second yellow card for the shove, the goalkeeper ran after Pulido

and hit him in the face with a powerful right-hand punch.

Pulido dropped to the ground and a brawl between players and staff members from both teams ensued. Andrada later apologized for his actions.

Huesca goalkeeper Dani Jimenez was also sent off for punching Andrada during the melee. Jimenez was suspended four matches for the punch.

The suspensions can be appealed.

Rayo player suspended: Rayo Vallecano player Isi Palazon was suspended a total of seven matches for his harsh complaints about the referee in his team's 3-3 draw against Real Sociedad on Sunday.

Potapova reaches semifinals at WTA 1,000-level event

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Anastasia Potapova dropped to her knees, put both hands on her face and started crying. The "explosion of emotions inside" came after the 56th-ranked Potapova beat Karolina Pliskova 6-1, 6-7 (4), 6-3 on Wednesday at the Madrid Open to become the first "lucky loser" to reach the semifinals of a WTA 1,000 event.

She almost gave up the victory, squandering three match points in the second set and having to come back from 3-1 down in the third against the former Number 1-ranked player. It's been an impressive run considering Potapova lost in the qualifying tournament and only got a place in the main draw as a so-called lucky loser following the withdrawal of another player.

"I (had) a few match points in the second set, on serve, but I couldn't manage my nerves at that time," she said. "It seems that this tournament keeps giving me second chances and I keep using them. So yeah, supper happy."

Russia-born Potapova said

final in 2016, when it lost to city rival Real Madrid.

"We tried," Atletico midfielder Koke Resurreccion said. "We started losing with that penalty, which was doubtful, but the team recovered and we could equalise with a penalty ourselves. We had the opportunities to win, but it will all be decided in the second leg. I think we played a good match."

Gyokeres broke the deadlock Wednesday from the penalty spot after he was brought down inside the area by Hancko, who was a bit late to the ball and slightly bumped the Arsenal striker from behind. The buildup came after Atletico lost possession in attack.

"Overall I think it was a tough game, we know it's a tough place to come, but it's only halftime," Gyokeres said. "We know when we play at home, with our fans, it's going to be different for sure and we just have to do our job, be at our best, and for sure it's going to be a good game at home." (AP)



Griezmann leads Atletico in his final Champions League



TALES AZZONIAP ■ Madrid

Antoine Griezmann made the most of his final home match with Atletico Madrid in the Champions League.

Griezmann didn't score despite having a few good opportunities, but he led Atletico's attack along with Julian Alvarez and was named the game's most valuable player following the 1-1 draw with Arsenal in the first leg of the semifinals.

"It's a shame I couldn't find the net," said Griezmann, who is joining MLS club Orlando City this summer.

"But it will happen in the

second leg for sure. We all put in a great effort."

Griezmann's best chance at the Metropolitano stadium was a second-half shot that hit the crossbar. He also came close with a strike from inside the area.

The 35-year-old Griezmann missed a penalty kick in the 2016 Champions League final that Atletico lost to Real Madrid.

"We want to reach the final," Griezmann said. "It's my dream. I've prepared a lot for this match and the one we will have in London, and hopefully we can make it to the final." (AP)

Droemer wins PGA Professional Championship



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bandon (US)

Jesse Droemer survived a late bogey by finishing with three pars at windy Bandon Dunes to close with a 2-under 70 and win the PGA Professional Championship by one shot Wednesday, one of 20 club pros who earned a spot in the PGA Championship.

Droemer, a teaching pro at Riverbend Country Club in the Houston area, was among six pros who qualified for the PGA Championship for the second year in a row. The PGA Championship is May 14-17 at Aronimink outside Philadelphia.

Ben Kern, the general manager at Hickory Hills Golf Club in central Ohio, made a pair of birdies on the back nine and tied for the lead when Droemer in the group ahead took bogey on the par-3 15th.

Wrexham aims to keep alive Premier League dream



STEVE DOUGLASAP ■ London

For Wrexham's growing global fanbase, it's set to be another heart-stopping end to the season.

This time, a place in the Premier League is at stake.

"I think a defibrillator is the traditional fifth season gift? Would make sense for this show," Ryan Reynolds, the Hollywood celebrity who is a co-owner of the club, wrote on X in a nod to the "Welcome to Wrexham" series that has documented the team's unprecedented journey up English soccer's league pyramid.

The final step is the biggest one, though.

On Saturday, Wrexham heads into the final round of regular-season games in the second-tier Championship aiming to secure a place in the playoffs that will determine the last promotion spot to the Premier League.

The top two teams go up automatically — one of them

is sure to be Coventry, which will finish first — and the teams finishing third to sixth will advance to the playoffs. With one match left, Wrexham is in sixth place.

That last playoff spot is a three-way contest between Wrexham, Hull (in seventh place, behind Wrexham on goal difference) and Derby (in eighth place, one point further back).

Wrexham has the toughest game — at home to fourth-place Middlesbrough, which needs to win to stand a chance of finishing in second spot.

Hull hosts ninth-place Norwich and Derby is at home to 15th-place Sheffield United. Wrexham is already assured of the highest finish in its 162-year history — its previous best was 15th in the second tier in the 1978-79 season — but still possible is a fourth straight promotion that would be beyond the owners' wildest dreams. (AP)

Rabada, Holder sparkle as GT bowl out RCB

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ahmedabad

Skipper Shubman Gill and Jos Buttler played useful knocks to help Gujarat Titans chase down defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru's modest total, securing a four-wicket win in their Indian Premier League match here on Thursday.

Despite RCB pacer Bhuvneshwar Kumar (3/28) tormenting the hosts, opener Gill scored a belligerent 43 off 18 balls, while Buttler smashed 39 off 19 to power Gujarat to their fifth win of the season and take their points tally to 10. They chased down a modest 155 in 15.5 overs for the loss of six wickets.

Earlier, RCB were dismissed in 19.2 overs with their batters struggling against the bowling attack led by Kagiso Rabada and Mohammed Siraj.

RCB, who are placed second on the points table, could not stitch together a fruitful partnership, losing wickets at regular intervals as Siraj (1/38) and Rabada (1/44) reduced them to 35 for 2 in the fourth over, from where they could not recover.

Left-arm pacer Arshad Khan (3/22) took the wickets of RCB skipper Rajat Patidar (19), Krunal Pandya (4) and Venkatesh Iyer (12), while Jason Holder (2/29) and Rashid Khan (2/19) also grabbed two wickets each.

Devdutt Padikkal was the highest run-getter for RCB, scoring 40 off 24 balls.

Earlier in the game, Gujarat



Titans pace spearhead Kagiso Rabada's victory over Virat Kohli in a much-anticipated duel was a fair reflection of Gujarat Titans' disciplined bowling effort while bundling out Royal Challengers Bengaluru for a modest 155 in their IPL match here on Thursday.

Returning to the venue where they had lifted the title last season, RCB were cruising at a run rate in excess of 10 with Kohli leading the charge, smashing Rabada for 21 runs in his opening over which included five fours in a row.

But skipper Shubman Gill persisted with his strike bowler, a call that paid off handsomely.

Rabada (1/38) struck back to remove Kohli for a blazing 28 off 13 balls, triggering a collapse as RCB lost wickets in a cluster through the middle phase.

Left-arm pacer Arshad Khan wrapped the tail and returned with 3/22. From a strong 71/2 after seven overs, RCB slipped to 96/6 in 10.3 overs, losing Rajat Patidar (19), Jitesh Sharma (1), Tim David (9) and Krunal Pandya (4).

However, RCB stuck to their all-out attacking template despite the slide, something that seemed to have denied them 20-30 extra runs and they were bowled out in 19.2 overs.

Amid the collapse, Devdutt Padikkal looked set to anchor the innings, with Romario Shepherd playing second fiddle.

But the ever-reliable Rashid Khan produced a peach to clean up Devdutt for 40 (24 balls), a skidding delivery that cramped him for room and led to a chop-on. The

wily Afghan returned with splendid figures of 2/19.

From GT's perspective, all-rounder Jason Holder (2/29) was everywhere -- picking up key wickets, including that of Shepherd, and grabbing three sharp catches.

Holder first pulled off a brilliant running catch near the deep square boundary to dismiss Patidar, holding on to the skier despite almost colliding with Rabada.

He then dismissed Jitesh before completing two smart takes at short midwicket to remove David and Krunal, capping an outstanding all-round effort.

Earlier, put in to bat, RCB lost two quick wickets after Kohli's early blitz, with Mohammed Siraj (1/38) providing the first breakthrough by dismissing opener Jacob Bethell (5).

The Kohli-Rabada contest lived up to its billing early on, with Kohli smashing him for five successive boundaries.

He began with a pull through midwicket, followed by a punch through mid-off, a crisp square drive, and a stylish cut through backward point.

Kohli then hammered Siraj for a flat six over mid-on to race to 28 off just 10 balls.

But Rabada had the final say. Tightening his line, the South African forced Kohli into a mistimed pull when he charged down and Rashid completed a good catch.

TNCA invites applications for men's senior head coach



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Cricket Association (TNCA) on Thursday invited applications for the men's senior state team head coach roles, seeking successors to M Senthilnathan and M Venkataramana.

The Association has also invited applications for the men's and women's state senior and junior selection committees. The deadline for all the applications is set on May 10. It may be recalled that Cricket Association of Bengal too recently adopted a similar method to find a successor to state head coach Laxmi Ratan Shukla.

The applicants for the coaches' role - separate for multi-day and white ball formats - should be below the age of 60, and should hold a

BCCI Level 2 or higher coaching certification, or any other equivalent certification.

"The selection process will be conducted in accordance with TNCA regulations, and shortlisted candidates will be invited for further evaluation," said TNCA Secretary U Bhagwandas Rao.

The shake-up in coaching structure was expected after the TN teams' modest outings in the last domestic season.

Senthilnathan took over from L Balaji ahead of the previous season, and, rather abruptly, Venkataramana was brought in as the white-ball coach in November last year ahead of the white ball competitions.

In Ranji Trophy, Tamil Nadu finished sixth in Group A with 14 points from seven matches and could only win one match in the 2025-26 season, losing two and drawing four.

Parag fined 25% of match fees for vaping incident



BHARAT SHARMA ■ New Delhi

Rajasthan Royals captain Riyan Parag was on Thursday fined 25 per cent of his match fee for bringing the game into "disrepute" after being caught vaping on camera during the IPL game against Punjab Kings in Mullanpur.

Parag's actions during the Royals' chase on Tuesday night drew condemnation on social media.

PTI has learned that on field umpires Tanmay Srivastava and Nitin Menon had not reported the matter to match referee Amit Sharma right after the game. They only did that after seeing visual proof and Sharma found Parag guilty for a code of conduct breach as per the IPL guidelines.

The Level 1 offence carries 25 per cent deduction from match fees and one demerit point.

"Riyan admitted to the offence and accepted the sanction imposed by the Match Referee, Amit Sharma," said the IPL in a statement.

"The BCCI is also exploring other options to initiate proceedings for stringent action against the erring team, its officials and players to ensure that the reputation of IPL remains intact," the statement added.

When PTI reached out to BCCI secretary Devajit Saika on possible action on Rajasthan Royals, he said: "As it is written clearly in the statement, we are exploring



what action to take on the team. It is not decided yet."

The Indian government had banned e-cigarettes back in 2019, prohibiting their production, sale and distribution. As per the law, the offender faces imprisonment up to one year and/or a ₹one lakh fine for a first time offence.

"Article 2.21 of IPL Code of Conduct is intended to cover all types of conduct that bring the game into disrepute and which is not specifically and adequately covered by the specific offences set out elsewhere in this Code of Conduct, including Article 2.20," the IPL Code of Conduct states.

"By way of example, Article 2.21 may (depending upon the seriousness and context of the breach) prohibit, without limitation, the following: (a) public acts of misconduct; (b) unruly public behaviour; and (c) inappropriate comments which are detrimental to the interests of the game. (PTI)

Spinners are not looking to turn the ball: Muralitharan

DEVARCHIT VARMA ■ Mumbai

Sri Lankan spin legend Muttiah Muralitharan believes spinners in the Indian Premier League are not looking to turn the ball as they have not developed the skills since young age and it is not possible to develop the art during the tournament.

Muralitharan said spinners nowadays do not develop the art of spinning the ball and making batters think as their focus remains on containing with variations.

"(The) domestic level (cricket) has also been like this for spinners. When we played cricket, as a spinner, you have



to turn the ball - that is your first objective. Nowadays, it's not the key because everyone is not looking at (playing) Test cricket. They are looking to play one-day cricket," Muralitharan told reporters here on Wednesday after

Sunrisers Hyderabad beat Mumbai Indians by six wickets.

"Even at a young age, they only try to bowl quicker, vary (the deliveries) and not try to spin it. Because they are not getting that ability from the younger days, they can't come (at the age of) 19s and 18s and try to spin the ball because their muscle memories are already there in place.

"When you are (at the) age of 10, 11, (or) 12, try to spin. That's the way we learnt. We need to spin to beat the bat," he added.

Muralitharan said batting against spinners in the IPL is like practicing against throw-



down specialists as it is all about getting in the line of the ball and smacking it.

"If you are a really good spinner, if you can spin the

and hit sixes," he said.

"It looks like a throwdown bowler bowling at you and you are getting into the line and hitting. That's the way the batsmen are playing. But if you spin, their eyes open. (They are forced to think) 'oh, it's spinning and I'm missing it'."

Muralitharan continued, "It's very difficult to teach (spin bowling). It has to come from them. But there are all coming in at the age of professional level. When you come one level higher, you have to improve their game. So some people do, some people go down so it's very difficult to come here in the IPL and improve spinners." (PTI)

Thomas Cup Finals: India take on Chinese Taipei in quarters



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Horsens (Denmark)

India will aim to stay on course for a second title when they face a formidable Chinese Taipei in the quarterfinals of the Thomas Cup Finals here on Friday.

Four years ago, India achieved an unprecedented feat by clinching the Thomas Cup crown -- the world team championship of badminton -- bringing the sport firmly into focus among the country's youth.

This time, India progressed to the quarterfinals after finishing second in Group A and will face Chinese Taipei, who are yet to win the title.

India made a strong start to their campaign with a 4-1 win over Canada, followed by a 5-0 sweep of Australia, before going down 2-3 to China despite a spirited effort.

Chinese Taipei, who topped Group C, is also a formidable side, led by world No. 6 Chou Tien Chen. Alongside him, world No. 8 and reigning All England champion Lin Chun-Yi and world No. 21 Chi Yu Jen add depth to their singles line-up.

Chun-Yi, currently one of the most attacking player, had defeated Lakshya in last month's All England Championships summit clash.

Starc boost for DC against high flying Rajasthan Royals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Jaipur

Delhi Capitals have little time to dwell on what has been a bruising stretch of results as they gear up to face a confident Rajasthan Royals in their Indian Premier League match here on Friday.

It has been a difficult run for the Axar Patel-led side this season. They have swung between extremes in the last two games. From posting a 250-plus total only to concede a world-record chase, to being bowled out for 75 against Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

Add to that a one-run defeat against Gujarat Titans earlier this month, and Delhi have had their share of emotionally damaging results. With three wins and four losses, they are seventh on the table and need a turnaround soon.

Delhi's biggest concern has been their inconsistent batting. While the likes of KL Rahul, David Miller, Tristan Stubbs and Sameer Rizvi have all contributed in patches, the unit has failed to click collectively.

In the last match, Abhishek Porel's knock as an Impact Player was one of the few positives, helping the team avoid a record-low total and the



team management will be tempted to give him a go in the playing XI.

There is some good news on the bowling front. Pace ace Mitchell Starc is set to return after getting clearance from Cricket Australia to play from May 1. With Lungi Ngidi still unavailable, Starc's inclusion comes as a timely boost. He is likely to replace either Kyle Jamieson or Dushmantha Chameera.

Delhi's bowlers couldn't do much while defending 75 in the previous game, but they will need to be sharper against a strong Rajasthan batting line-up.

Playing one format affects rhythm but Ro-Ko will manage: Shikhar Dhawan

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi

Having himself been an ODI-only player towards the end of his career, Shikhar Dhawan understands how lack of match frequency can disrupt rhythm but feels it won't be an issue for Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli as they will have enough games under their belt heading into the 2027 World Cup.

Drawing from his own experience of transitioning into a one-format regular, Dhawan acknowledged that reduced match frequency can disrupt a player's flow. "Yes, when you play one format at the International level, your flow does get disrupted," Dhawan told PTI during an interview.

"So players focus on fitness because you are not playing too many games.



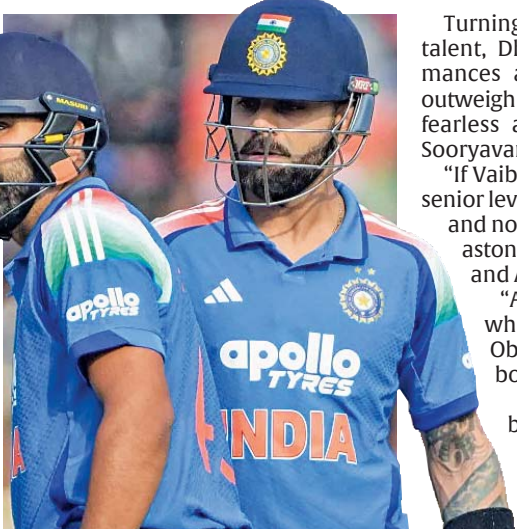
You are talking about Rohit and Virat and they are matured individuals. It is a challenge but they know how to convert challenge into an opportunity.

"If you look at their fitness, Virat was

always fit but Rohit has undergone tremendous transformation," the man with nearly 7000 ODI runs said.

Reflecting on how scheduling dynamics shape preparation, he pointed out that the lead-up to the next ODI World Cup will offer ample opportunities for the senior duo to be in rhythm.

"Now with 2027 WC round the corner, they will get to play a lot of ODI matches. If you look at the time when I became a one format player, there were back to back T20 World Cups (2021 and 22) and I was playing ODIs which were few and far between. So matches won't be a problem for Rohit and Virat and there's enough time for the event."



Turning his attention to emerging talent, Dhawan stressed that performances at the highest level should outweigh concerns about age, citing the fearless approach of young Vaibhav Sooryavanshi.

"If Vaibhav is doing brilliantly at the senior level then that has to be counted and not his age. Yes he is a kid but its astonishing the way he hits Bumrah and Arshdeep for such huge sixes.

"A lot of big guns haven't done what he has at such small age. Obviously his time will come. It's bound to come."

He underlined the difficulty of breaking into a settled top order, drawing parallels with his own long stint alongside Rohit and Kohli.

"Look if top order is doing well you can't readily replace them. When me Ro and Virat were playing, we nearly played for a decade and it wasn't easy to replace us.

"It is up to the individual how they take it. It can pinch you a bit but one shouldn't be disheartened if the chance doesn't come along readily. Vaibhav has so much blessings at this young age."

Observing the evolution of batting philosophies in T20 cricket, Dhawan noted the shift from conservative beginnings to a more aggressive template, while still valuing sound technique.

"When we started our coaches said that hit along the ground and now it is opposite. Like Vaibhav has good defense as I have watched him defend close to his body." (PTI)